Imagining a new Chineseness: Chinese Students' Theatre in the United States, 1906-1931

by

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Abstract

This paper brings forth research on the Chinese international students theatre (CST) in the U.S. between 1906 and 1931. This deeply understudied field, often dismissed because of its amateur status and sparse archival records, offers valuable insights into how performance enabled Chinese students to negotiate their foreign identity under the precarities, misrepresentations, and nostalgia. This study reconstructs CST performance histories by assembling archival evidence from *The Chinese Students' Monthly*, *Chinese Students' Quarterly* 留美學生季報, and *The Chinese Students' Christian Journal* alongside newspaper coverage, memoirs, and surviving manuscripts. Drawing on these materials, I would argue, CST performances, as a form of amateur intercultural theatre, becomes a site where knowledge is translated and produced, and where visibility, representation, and community formation are negotiated across linguistic and cultural boundaries in the early twentieth century. In this process, CIST generated new forms of "Chineseness" that shaped not only American spectators' understanding of China, but also Chinese students' understanding of themselves.

Acknowledgement

The sense of finishing the thesis is surprisingly exhausting, rather than the excitement that I would have anticipated one year ago when I began this project. What I have learnt in the past year is that there is so much more work to be done, but we are running out of time. How much time do we still have to even understand our own history before everything is flooded away by large language models or AI?

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INTRODUCTION: THE OTHER SIDE OF THE PACIFIC

"O! You wandering lonely bird!
Where are you flying to?
The other side of the Pacific,
Do you know what is over there?"

流落的孤禽啊！
到底飛住哪裡去呢？
那太平洋底彼岸，
可知道究竟有些什麼？

—Yiduo Wen 聞一多, *Gu Yan* 孤雁

On August 17th, 1923, a group of Chinese students stepped aboard *SS President Jackson*, heading toward Seattle, United States, waiting to start their student life in America. As Shiqiu Liang 梁實秋 recalled, "some of them had eyes swollen red from crying…When the ship finally pulled away from the dock…the crowd seeing us off gradually blurred into the distance, and all of our faces became numb."[1] Later we would know that the ship also transported Yuxiu Gu 顧毓琇 and Wanying Xie 謝婉瑩(more commonly known as Bingxin 冰心), who became major cultural and literary figures in the early 20th century China. Three of them had all actively participated in various theatrical activities in America, and they had together produced *Pee Pa Chi* in 1925 at the Boston Fine Art Theatre. Why did they care about theatre? What could theatre productions by some Chinese international students in America do? To explore these questions, I would begin with the background of their study in America.

Chinese students started to study in America in the late 19th century due to the humiliations China suffered since Late Qing (1839-1912). Chinese defeats in the two Opium Wars forced China to confront its military weakness and political vulnerability before foreign

[1] "其中有些只眼睛是紅腫的……等到船離開了碼頭……送行的人群漸漸模糊，我們人人臉上都露出了木然的神情。" Shiqiu Liang, *Liang Shiqiu Zizhuan* 梁實秋自傳 [Autobiography of Liang Shiqiu] (Jiangsu Wenyi Chubanshe, 1996), 92.

powers. Under the call of *zhongti xiyong* 中體西用 (Chinese values as essence, Western learning for practical), Chinese government sent students across the sea to study Western technical knowledge to strengthen China. The first wave of Chinese students in America began with the Chinese Educational Mission in 1872 and ended abruptly in 1881, when the Qing government recalled the students. The mission ended because Qing officials worried Chinese students became Americanized and the anti-Chinese policies in the United States.[2]

Moving into the early 20th century, as political crises continued to outburst in China, Chinese students once again began traveling to the United States. This time, they were not only seeking technical knowledge, but also engaging with Western learning more broadly.[3] The establishment of the Boxer Indemnity Scholarship Program strengthened the second wave of Chinese students who traveled to the United States. Signed by President Theodore Roosevelt in 1908, the program ironically returned the excess portion of the Boxer Indemnity remission that China itself paid to the United States to fund Chinese students who wish to be educated in American institutions. The second wave of Chinese overseas study continued for several decades before gradually coming to an end with the outbreak of the Second Sino-Japanese War and World War II, which made study abroad increasingly difficult. Between 1905-1949, there were about 30,000 Chinese students who had traveled to America and studied there.[4]

Living in-between

What could be on the other side of the Pacific? The answer for most Chinese students at the time was far from being a promised land. Their expectation of learning from one of the most state-of-the-art countries was disrupted by a world of uncertainty, racial prejudice, cultural

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[2] Weili Ye, *Seeking Modernity in China's Name: Chinese Students in the United States, 1900–1927* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2001), 8.
[3] Ibid. 9.
[4] Jan Stacey Bieler, "The Lost Reformers: Chinese Students in the United States from 1906–1931" (MA thesis, Michigan State University, 1994), 1.

misrepresentation, and mixed expectations. Although Chinese students are commonly understood as having experienced less racial prejudice in universities than other Chinese immigrants, they were certainly not exempt from it.[5] In 1924, an American student published a poem in *The Colorado College Tiger*, mocking the "Chinee": "Behind your mask-like face, /…/ Do you know all that we say? / Or do you puzzle over thoughts / Which are innate to us?"[6] In the same year, as Shiqiu Liang later recalled, Chinese students experienced another humiliating moment at Yiduo Wen's graduation ceremony at Colorado College. According to the college's custom, graduating students walked in pairs, one male student beside one female student, to receive their degrees. Because no American female students were willing to walk beside the Chinese students, the college arranged the six graduating Chinese men to walk together in three pairs.[7] Shen Hong 洪深 also wrote in his memoir that "no matter how Americans praised you, were polite with you, or were close to you, that sense of discrimination against Chinese people always slipped through and made you uncomfortable."[8]

Beyond these experiences of being discriminated against, Chinese students also saw their images distorted and falsely accused in the public. As Josephine Lee observed, Americans began to see China as a "land of exotic excess" in the seventeenth century.[9] The appropriation of

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[5] By "other Chinese immigrants," I refer primarily to working-class Chinese immigrants in the United States, who work as railroad workers, miners, laundrymen, cooks, and other laborers. It is commonly understood that the Chinese students were treated differently from the Chinese laborers because of their association with American universities and class differences.

[6] "Literary Corner," The Tiger (Colorado Springs, CO), March 25, 1924, 4, in The Tiger (student newspaper), Sept. 1923–June 1924, vol. 26.

[7] Shiqiu Liang, *Tan Wen Yiduo* 談聞一多[Talk about Wen Yiduo] (Taipei: Zhuanji Wenxue Chubanshe, 1967), 48.

[8] "但是無論怎樣美國人恭敬你，待你有禮貌，和你親熱，那鄙視華人的心理，不知不覺地會顯露出來，使得你感到了難受." Hong Shen, "Yinxiang de Zizhuan" 印象的自傳 [An Impressionistic Autobiography], in *Hong Shen Wenji* 洪深文集 [Collected Works of Hong Shen], vol. 4 (Zhongguo Xiju Chubanshe, 1959), 512.

[9] Josephine Lee, "Stage Orientalism and Asian American Performance from the Nineteenth into the Twentieth Century," in *The Cambridge History of Asian American Literature*, ed. Rajini Srikanth and Min Hyoung Song (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015), 56.

Chinese themes as exotic attractions in America continued into the 19th and early 20th century, accompanied by increasingly hostile depictions of Chinese people.[10] J. S. Tow complained that the American "portray… foreign people in the worst caricature one can imagine, and make them do what they actually do not."[11] After seeing an American production of *Mr. Wu*, P. C. Chang [Pengchun Zhang] 張彭春 wrote, "What we do hope is that the play may not have increased the common misconceptions regarding the Chinese people . . . and that people who see it may distinguish clearly what is Chinese and what comes purely from the country beyond time and space, of fancy and imagination."[12]

These Chinese students also lived under constant pressure to negotiate between retaining their Chinese traditions and becoming Americanized. On the one hand, they embraced Western culture, hoping that by learning it they could use it to strengthen and save China. The American government also saw their overseas studies as an opportunity to exert American influences on these Chinese students. As Edmund J. James, president of the University of Illinois, wrote in the letter to Secretary of State Philander Knox in 1905, James saw inviting Chinese students to American institutions to study as a way for the United States to establish moral, intellectual, and commercial influences on China:

> If the United States had succeeded thirty-five years ago, as it looked at one time as if it might, in turning the current of Chinese students to this country, and had succeeded in keeping that current large, we should today be controlling the development of China in

[10] For example, in 1834, Afong Moy, the first Chinese woman to gain public fame in the United States, was exhibited in New York as an exotic attraction used to promote Chinese goods. In theatres, works such as *The Pearl of Pekin* (1888), *A Trip to Chinatown* (1891), and *A Chinese Honeymoon* (1902) appropriated Chinese settings under Western structure to attract American audiences. At the same time, plays such as *Ah Sin* (1877) and *The Chinese Must Go* (1879) helped define public images of the Chinese as comic, deceitful, or dangerous "Chinamen."

[11] J. S. Tow, "Chinese Plays Seen Through Chinese Eyes," *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 15, no. 3 (1920), 43.

[12] P. C. Chang, "Chinese Themes on the Stage: A Comment on 'Mr. Wu,'" *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 10, no. 4, 218–22.

> that most satisfactory and subtile of all ways, —through the intellectual and spiritual domination of its leaders.[13]

John R. Mott, a longtime leader of the Young Man Christian Association(YMCA), similarly wrote: "At present China is plastic but will soon become fixed like plaster. Shall she set in molds of militarism, gross materialism and racial antagonism, or of good will, idealism and helpfulness? This question will be answered in the near and not in the distant future. *But by whom*?"(my emphasis)[14] On the other hand, they were also aware that becoming too Americanized will lead to the loss of their own identity. In Woon Yung Chun's [Huanyong Chen] 陳煥鏞 1914 story "East is East and West is West," a Chinese student leaves his newly engaged fiancée to study at an American college. He quickly becomes Americanized, falls in love with a new-style girl, and never returns to his heartbroken fiancée back in China.[15] Although the author praises the new ideas of the West and disregards the traditional Chinese marriage in the story, he also frames the protagonist's Americanization as an act of betrayal. The story therefore represents a prevalent ambivalence among Chinese students toward Americanization.

How do we understand these struggles of the early 20th-century Chinese students in America? First, I propose to read it through the lens of Orientalism, which Said defines, first, as a "style of thought based upon an ontological and epistemological distinction made between 'the Orient' and … 'the Occident,'" and second, as a "Western style for dominating, restructuring, and having authority over the Orient."[16] Orientalism provided a conceptual foundation for discrimination based on their provenance, while enabling the West to appropriate and represent

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[13] Edmund J. James, "Memorandum Concerning the Sending of an Educational Commission to China," March 3, 1905, University of Illinois Archives, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign.
[14] Liping Bu, *Making the World Like Us: Education, Cultural Expansion, and the American Century* (Westport, CT: Praeger, 2003), 25.
[15] Woon Yung Chun, "East is East and West is West," *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 9, no. 6 (1914), 491–92.
[16] Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (1978; repr., London: Penguin Books, 2003), 2–3.

Chinese. Furthermore, it defined the West with modernity and the East with the archaic, a logic epitomized by Hegel's notorious declaration that "the History of the World travels from East to West, for Europe is absolutely the end of History, Asia the beginning."[17] Under this definition, the West maintained a positional superiority to the East in time.

But Orientalism itself was insufficient to understand the complex situations of these Chinese students; it must also be read through the concept of diaspora. The term "diaspora" originally referred to the dispersal of peoples such as Jews, Greeks, and Armenians from their homelands. By the late twentieth century, Khachig Tölölyan had expanded the term beyond these classical cases of dispersion, using it to describe a wider field of displaced communities.[18] In the same issue, William Safran defined the state of being diasporic as dispersal from a homeland, partial rejection by the host society, the retention of collective memory and connection to the homeland, and a hope for eventual return.[19] Although Chinese overseas students were not traditionally understood as part of the diaspora, recent scholarship has increasingly brought them into diasporic discourse.[20] As Yu Jing proposed, Chinese international students can be understood as "Diaspora in the Making," a "temporary mobile" population that maintains "transnational ties" and is positioned "vis-à-vis both homeland and host societies."[21]

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[17] G. W. F. Hegel, *The Philosophy of History*, trans. J. Sibree (Amherst, NY: Prometheus Books, 1991), 121.
[18] See Khachig Tölölyan, "The Nation-State and Its Others: In Lieu of a Preface," *Diaspora: A Journal of Transnational Studies* 1, no. 1 (1991): 3–7, https://doi.org/10.1353/dsp.1991.0008.
[19] William Safran, "Diasporas in Modern Societies: Myths of Homeland and Return," *Diaspora: A Journal of Transnational Studies* 1, no. 1 (1991), 83–84.
[20] See Rachel Brooks and Johanna Waters, "International Students and Alternative Visions of Diaspora," *British Journal of Educational Studies* 69, no. 5 (2021): 557-77, https://doi.org/10.1080/00071005.2021.1948501; Bin Wu, "Chinese Student Migration and Community-Building: An Exploration of New Diasporic Formation in England," in *Contemporary Chinese Diasporas*, ed. Min Zhou (Singapore: Palgrave Macmillan, 2017), 309-30, https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-10-5595-9_14.
[21] Jing Yu, "Between Soft Power and Suspicion: Chinese International Students as Diasporic Actors in U.S.–China Geopolitical Tensions," *British Educational Research Journal* (2026): 6–7, https://doi.org/10.1002/berj.70166.

By combining Orientalism with diasporic discourse, we can understand an existential crisis of the Chinese students, which I call the state of being "in-between." These Chinese students belonged to the "special generation" who had "Confucian learning etched into their memories," while at the same time confronting "the intrusive Western world forcing itself into Chinese territory and Chinese minds."[22] They were caught between empire and republic, old and new, Chinese memory and Western education. Unlike contemporary Chinese international students, early twentieth-century Chinese students were not only crossing geographic boundaries; they were also crossing a historical time. The asynchronicity between Western and Chinese time produced a paradox for their homecoming desire. In common diaspora literature, the homeland is associated with the past, as Salman Rushdie suggests when he writes that "the past is a country from which we have all emigrated, that its loss is part of our common humanity."[23] For these Chinese students, however, the homeland cannot reside in a lost past. Imperial China should be left behind, and the only homeland that they could "return" to is in the future, a civilized, modern future built by them. But whose modernity were they building? If modernization came to mean Americanization(Westernization), then they were equally hesitant to move toward it, since doing so distanced them from their own cultural identity. Therefore, the Chinese students were placed "in-between" a contradiction: they should neither fully return to their own traditions, nor fully move toward a Western modernity.[24]

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[22] Jon L. Saari, Legacies of Childhood: Growing Up Chinese in a Time of Crisis, 1890–1920 (Cambridge, MA: Council on East Asian Studies, Harvard University, 1990), ix.
[23] Salman Rushdie, "Imaginary Homelands," in *Imaginary Homelands: Essays and Criticism 1981–1991* (London: Granta Books, 1991), 12.
[24] It is important to note, however, that this condition did not begin only when they became students abroad; it was already inscribed in their educational trajectory. Many Chinese students in the early twentieth-century had been trained in Confucian schools during childhood, moved to newly established Westernized institutions, and later attended American universities.

Nevertheless, the "in-between" condition should not be understood only as an existential crisis. It also echoes what Samir Dayal calls a "diasporic double consciousness," a condition of "neither just this/nor just that."[25] The state of being not "just" implies the potential for the Chinese students to adopt and reject different values through a cautious process of selection. During a speech in 1925, Tseng Ku Chuan [Zenggu Quan] 全增嘏 advocated that the Chinese students should "be radically foreignized," but only by assimilating "that part of Western culture and civilization which is really worth while."[26] Quan's selective position recalls Weili Ye's argument that the construction of Chinese modernity involved both borrowing from the modern West and reconnecting with China's own history and tradition.[27] Furthermore, this position of "neither/nor" fostered a style of thinking from nowhere/everywhere. As T. H. K. wrote, "The East treasures its history, its past; is [sic] has no future. The West ignores its history; it has a risky future."[28] The tendency to speak of "the East" and "the West" on such a vast historical scale, as if they stood outside/between the histories of both, persisted in early twentieth-century Chinese student writings. Such a mindset reveals a cosmopolitan mode of thought that maintains an awareness of cultural differences through constant learning and reflection.

Literature Review

The Chinese students had adopted many strategies to cope with these struggles, and it would be beyond the scope of the thesis to explore all the aspects. Generally speaking, Chinese students formed organizations to unite themselves and support one another, such as the formation of the Chinese Students' Alliance. They also wrote in local and university newspapers,

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[25] Samir Dayal, "Diaspora and Double Consciousness," *The Journal of the Midwest Modern Language Association* 29, no. 1 (1996): 47-48.
[26] Tseng Ku Chuan, "An Appeal to a Radical Foreignization of Chinese Students Abroad," *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 20, no. 6 (1925): 20.
[27] See Ye, *Seeking Modernity in China's Name*, 6.
[28] T. H. K., "Confucius and John Dewey: The Bankruptcy of the East and the West," *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 16, no. 8 (June 1921): 539.

participated in athletic competitions, performances, student clubs, public lectures to promote their cultures and promote friendship between Chinese and Americans. Existing scholarship has examined many of these strategies: Weili Ye's *Seeking Modernity in China's Name* provides a foundational study of Chinese students' experiences in America, especially their efforts to negotiate between racism, nationalism, and the pressures of modernization. Jan Stacey Bieler's *Patriots or Traitors* examines three figures, Hengzhe Chen 陳衡哲, Henry Fearing, and Hu Shi 胡適, and shows how they acted as "student ambassadors" through their activities in the United States. More recently, Hin Heng Antonio Tang, in his doctoral dissertation read Chinese students' activities as rhetorical action against Orientalism. Tang argues that Chinese students tried to reshape American images of the Chinese through embodied practices, including writing, public speaking, performance, social events, athletics, and conference organization. While these studies have shown the broad variety of Chinese students' responses, fewer have focused on one specific site: theatre. Although often overlooked, it is arguable that the Chinese students theatrical productions staged across American campuses were one of the earliest attempts through which Chinese overseas communities resisted the yellow peril sentiment under the continuing regime of Chinese exclusion in the early 20th century.

Often performed as part of Chinese students conferences, celebrations, and fundraising programs, Chinese students theatre(CST) has been a popular form of Chinese student performance in America. Many of the studies on CST appeared in Chinese-language scholarship, focusing on two famous playwrights, Pengchun Zhang and Shen Hong. Dozens of articles have been devoted to them, but none of them have written extensively on their work in America. Most of the paper treated the two playwrights' work in America as a raw experiment of modern Chinese drama which they eventually would develop when they returned to China, and only a

few of these articles consulted English-language sources. All of the articles present a similar May fourth narration, and their analysis focuses on how Zhang and Hong's plays have contributed to the expression of nationalism and Westernized modernization.[29] No systematic study on CST has appeared in Chinese-language scholarship.

The earliest systematic discussion of CST appears in Weili Ye's *Seeking Modernity in China's Name.* Ye devotes roughly half a chapter to CST, categorizing the plays into three types: works that illustrated China's past and contemporary conditions, works that reflected on political and social issues, and works adapted from Chinese myths. He offers a few examples for each type, and concludes the chapter encouraging the scholarship to consider CST's influence on modern Chinese theatre. Later, Hin Heng Antonio Tang discusses CST in greater detail in his doctoral dissertation "The Nation, the Group, the Individual: Towards an Embodied Rhetorical History of Early 20th Century Chinese University Students in America", especially its role in resisting misrepresentation. Tang divides CST productions into plays that are centered on Chinese mythology and plays not based on mythology. According to Tang, mythological plays often presented traditional Chinese virtues while connecting them to nationalist themes and contemporary concerns. In doing so, they reinforced positive images of Chinese character and helped American audiences understand current affairs in China. Non-mythological performances, by contrast, were crafted to educate directly American audiences about Chinese institutions,

[29] For example, Weijian Yang's "Gentry, Family-State, and National Salvation in Hong Shen's Early Drama *Rainbow,*" and Chao Gao, Chen Wang's "A Study of P. C. Chang's 'Modernizing' Dramatic Thought" both present a similar May fourth discourse. It should be straightforward to tell just from their titles. Yang Weijian 杨位俭, "Hong Shen Zaoqi Huaju 'Hong' Zhong de Shishen, Jiaguo yu Jiuwang" 洪深早期话剧《虹》中的士绅、家国与救亡 ["Gentry, Family-State, and National Salvation in Hong Shen's Early Drama *Rainbow*"], *Hangzhou Shifan Daxue Xuebao (Shehui Kexue Ban)* 杭州师范大学学报（社会科学版）47, no. 1 (2025): 62–67, https://doi.org/10.19925/j.cnki.issn.1674-2338.2025.01.006; Gao Chao 高超 and Wang Chen 王晨, "Zhang Pengchun 'Xiandaihua' Xiju Sixiang Yanjiu" 张彭春"现代化"戏剧思想研究 ["A Study of P. C. Chang's 'Modernizing' Dramatic Thought"], *Jinhua Zhiye Jishu Xueyuan Xuebao* 金华职业技术学院学报 24, no. 2 (2024): 80-86.

social conditions, and political issues. Although both Ye and Tang provide clear descriptions of CST as a whole and explain how these performances used dramatic content to serve representational, social, and political purposes, a key gap remains in their research. Both of them rely extensively on the *Chinese Students' Monthly*, which usually offers only brief plot summaries and occasional reviews. Partly due to the lack of evidence, their analyses remain on the surface. Only dramatic plots were introduced, but no textual or performance analysis on any production has been done.

The only focused study on CST is an undergraduate thesis at Cornell entitled "Performing Authenticity: Chinese Student Drama in the U.S., 1910-1923" written by Hui Tong in 2018. In his study, Tong examines how CST transformed Chinese traditions into a timeless essence in the construction of modern Chinese identity. He successfully identified the tension between the Chinese traditions and the Western modernity that the Chinese students were actively engaging with, but his study overlooks the agency of Chinese traditions themselves in shaping this intercultural encounter. Moreover, his analysis focuses primarily on the literary aspects of the plays, paying little attention to their theatrical dimensions. Some of the works he discusses, although written in the United States, were never performed there. Consequently, the receptions of CST in America were rarely discussed in his thesis.

Professor Man He took the problem of "in-between" further through discussing two major Chinese dramatists' works, Shen Hong and Shangyuan Yu 余上沅, when they study in America. Her analysis, for the first time, reinterprets CST's use of Chinese traditions as active forces in shaping modernity rather than as passive remnants of the past. In the first chapter of *Backstaging Modern Chinese Theatre*, she offers a detailed analysis of Hong's theatrical work in America, particularly *The Wedded Husband*, which she interprets as a performance through

which Chinese students negotiated their cultural identities, reinterpreted modernization, and enacted cosmopolitanism. In addition, He explored Yu's experience of learning and making theatres in America. She argues that through these experiences, Yu formed a unique practice of realist theatre that was shaped by both Chinese traditions and Western practices. He is also the first scholar to offer a detailed analysis of specific CST productions, but much remains to be examined. He's study centers on the two famous dramatists, which leaves out much of CST work by ordinary Chinese students unexamined.

The thesis will attempt to address these gaps in previous scholarship. First, I seek to continue exploring how Chinese students deal with the problem of "in-between" through theatre. Second, through a more thorough search of archival materials, I would hope to recover more detailed accounts of CST that were once lost in history. Finally, by focusing more on its immediate American context, I would explore what CST means to the American audiences as well as the students who were producing these performances. I would argue that CST, drawing on its intercultural context, produced a powerful anti-Orientalist discourse. Although being raw and amateur, these performances opened a site where knowledge was translated and produced, and where visibility and representation were negotiated across linguistic and cultural boundaries. During the process, a new, unstable, vivid Chineseness emerged on stage.[30]

Material and Methodology

As previously discussed, the major source of CST is the *Chinese Students' Monthly*(CSM). The periodical was published by the Chinese Students Alliance between

[30] By Chineseness, I follow the same definitions as Hin heng Antonio Tang explains as the "cultural elements (speech, dress, practice, foodways) that these students considered to be distinct to the Chinese." Note that I'm not hinting on an essentializing definition that considers such cultural elements exists in a definite state, but consider it both fluid and in relation to American values. Hin Heng Antonio Tang, "The Nation, the Group, the Individual: Towards an Embodied Rhetorical History of Early 20th-Century Chinese University Students in America" (PhD diss., University of Wisconsin–Madison, 2019), 48.

November 1905 and April 1931. It usually published eight issues per volume, spanning from November to June and roughly corresponding to one academic year. The periodical included local and international news, essays, Alliance business reports, club reports, creative writing, and advertisements. Most information about CST appears in the club reports activities. I have also used CSM's Chinese-language counterpart, the *Chinese Students' Quarterly*(CSQ) 留美學生季報, and *The Chinese Students' Christian Journal*(CSCJ) as a supplementary source. The former was published between 1914 to 1928, while the latter, published by the Chinese Students' Christian Association in North America, ran briefly from 1914 to 1921. Using CSM, CSQ, and CSCJ as the basis of my archival research, I have also investigated the local and university newspapers. Most of the local newspaper sources were located through keyword searches on Newspapers.com. If specific productions lead to known names, I have also performed searches on their manuscripts, memoirs and published plays. Based on these materials, I have compiled a catalogue of all CST productions I discovered between 1906-1931.[31] The catalogue is, to the author's best knowledge, the most complete record of CST productions from this period.

Although this study has recovered many previously overlooked materials, reconstructing the performances remains difficult, as is often the case in theatre history. Of the roughly one hundred productions recorded in the catalogue, only twelve scripts were located, and photographs of the productions were even rarer. Therefore, in analyzing the archival materials, I adopted the following principles: First, the thesis will focus on the reception of these productions, as the surviving sources are most abundant in this area. What was perceived was always shaped by evaluations grounded in the audiences' backgrounds, and what audiences chose to report, as well as what they chose to omit, can sometimes offer clues to their spectatorship. Nevertheless, as Yizhou Huang points out in her analysis of Shanghai A.D.C.

[31] See Appendix A.

productions, newspaper reports of amateur productions were seldom signed and were often written by supporters of the theatrical group, or even by members of the group themselves.[32] Therefore, any analysis of the reception of CST productions based on newspaper reports will always start with a consideration of the author's positionality when possible. Second, the thesis adopts what Judith Milhous and Robert D. Hume defined as production analysis as a way of reading theatrical texts in the archive:

> "By this term we mean interpretation of the text specifically aimed at understanding it as a performance vehicle—-"reading with a directorial eye," if you like. While heavily grounded in textual analysis, such criticism will be undertaken on the principle that what should emerge is a sense of multiple possibilities in actual performance. Production analysis should draw freely on theatre history and drama history. Particular productions will be studied for what they can tell us about the potentialities of the script, but the critic is in no way limited to what has been staged. The results will sometimes resemble instructions for performance, but practically speaking they will be no more than a preliminary hint to the director, necessarily lacking the detail required for actual execution of a performance. A production analysis is a series of architect's sketches, not the blue prints that would be necessary to bring any one of them to actuality. The object is to clarify possible meanings and effects, primarily for readers, critics, and theatregoers, secondarily for the interested director. The result should be improved understanding of the performance potentialities of the play at issue."[33]

To appreciate the significance of amateur work such as CST, one must recognize that many of these works were undoubtedly limited in literary value. Moreover, the language barriers of many CST productions often made the spoken text less central. Production analysis therefore allows this thesis to examine theatrical aspects that cannot be fully captured through textual analysis alone. The search for "performance potentialities" of the productions, however, should not limit itself within the texts. In Man He's analysis of Hong Shen's *The Wedded Husband,* she ended with the following:

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[32] Yizhou Huang, "Cosmopolitan Performance and Its Ecologies in Interwar Shanghai" (PhD diss., Tufts University, 2021), 50.
[33] Judith Milhous and Robert D. Hume, *Producible Interpretation: Eight English Plays, 1675–1707* (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 1985), 10.

> The tension between the theatrical illusion and the reality of the actors perhaps caused the audience to shift their attention back and forth between the dramatic story and the real interracial intimacy. Hong and Vogel performed interracial intimacy drastically differently from the mainstream American theatrical norm. On those two April nights in 1919, in the OSU Chapel, an audience of over thirteen hundred Chinese and Americans were presented with a memorable event: a potent and handsome Chinese man expressing his longing for a Caucasian woman in a manner that was deemed neither threatening nor comical.[34]

He's attention to the discrepancy between the "theatrical illusion" and the "reality of the actors" proves particularly fruitful for understanding the unusual cross-racial intimacy staged in the production, an element never mentioned in contemporary newspaper reports. The audience's reactions may never be known, but the striking novelty of the performance itself cannot be erased. By reading between the lines of all available production elements, this thesis asks both "What did these productions do?" and "What could these productions have done?"

Scope and Boundaries

The temporal frame of this study is 1906-1931, a period within the second wave of Chinese students in America. The particular time frame was chosen mainly because the *CSM* has preserved materials only from these years. In addition, as Weili Ye argues, 1927 marked the beginning of a new Nationalist era and the return of many members of the earlier overseas student generation, which also resulted in a decline of the student-organized theatrical activity. Geographically, this thesis focuses on Chinese students studying in the continental United States. Hawaii is excluded because of the island's large Chinese immigrant population and its intricate Chinese social networks, which often make it difficult to distinguish overseas students from locally based Chinese students. The distinct social, racial, and cultural contexts between the two populations would require more detailed differentiation that is beyond the scope of this thesis.

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[34] Man He, *Backstaging Modern Chinese Theatre: Intellectuals, Amateurs, and Cultural Entrepreneurs, 1910s–1940s* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2025), 53.

Most of the sources examined document CST activities in the Northeast and Midwest, likely because these regions were especially popular destinations for Chinese students.

One of the major difficulties during the research was to determine what performance as theatrical work, as a clear definition did not exist at that time. In *Theatre Histories: An Introduction*, Tobin Nellhaus defined "drama" in the following way: "'Drama' is generally used to describe written plays with fictional characters and actions, even if based on historical people and events, that are performed live. Occasionally, it's used more broadly to refer to what is performed onstage, no matter how the fiction was devised; the drama might not be a script at all, just ideas and character types in the performers' minds." He further defined "theatre" as "live performances of drama (or something drama-like) by skilled artists for live audiences, and "performance" as "embodied presentation on stage (or with surrogates for the body, such as puppets).[35] While many Chinese student performances that called themselves "plays" fit the definition of "theatre" above, there were also many performances that contained little or no obvious "fiction." Some productions stood on the blurry line between theatre and a series of exhibitions loosely connected by a pseudo-storyline, while in other cases it was difficult to determine whether a selection from Chinese opera should be understood merely as a song or as a theatrical piece. The very category of "theatre" or "drama", as a newly introduced Western idea, was itself unstable in early twentieth-century China. For this reason, this thesis will expand on Nellhaus's definition of theatre and treat all Chinese students' performances that contain roughly a storyline as subjects of this study.

Lastly, the thesis's focus on performances staged by Chinese student groups does not mean that Chinese students were not also actively involved in theatrical productions elsewhere

[35] Tobin Nellhaus, "General Introduction," in Theatre Histories: An Introduction, 4th ed., by Tobin Nellhaus, Daphne P. Lei, Tamara Underiner, and Patricia Ybarra (London: Routledge, 2024), 1.

during their studies in the United States. For example, *The Thrice-Promised Bride*, written by Chen-Chin Hsiung [Zhengjin Xiong] 熊正瑾 was produced by the Carolina Playmakers with an American cast and toured throughout North Carolina between 1924 and 1925.[36] The first female architect in modern China, Huiyin Lin 林徽因 designed the scenic for Katherine Clugston's 1928 comedy *Finished* at Yale. Many Chinese students acted, designed, wrote, and otherwise contributed to theatrical work in their universities. A fuller examination of these activities would require a separate study.

Chapter Outline

The thesis is organized into two chapters and each focusing on one recurring theme in CST. Chapter one starts with the exploration of the larger performance programs, with a particular attention to how these performance programs reorganize spatial structure within the universities. The chapter then analyzes how "Chinese school," as a recurring theme in CST, functioned within the American school. It ends with the discussion of how Confucianism, the foundation of traditional Chinese school, has been staged and understood in relation to Western ideas.

Chapter two focuses on another theme, the "Chinese Wedding" as both an important image in American theatre and CST. It explores the risk of exoticism in the repeat presentation of "Chinese Weddings," and shows how CST had strived to fight the misrepresentations and Western exploitation. The first half of the chapter devotes itself to a case study of Shen hong's *The Wedded Husband*, while the second half writes on the new Chinese marriages on stage.

This thesis provides as much information as possible to ensure accessibility for both international and Chinese scholars. All Chinese terms and names, upon their first appearance, will appear in *pinyin* romanization with traditional Chinese characters and an English translation

[36] The play was also produced by Chinese students in 1926 by Columbia Student club.

if possible. All Chinese quotations are translated into English, with the original Chinese provided in the footnotes. After its first appearance, the thesis will refer to the term by its *pinyin* romanization. Occasionally, authors' names in primary sources are signed in Wade-Giles romanization or appear in abbreviated forms. In such cases, this thesis will always preserve the original spelling when discussing the primary sources, and provide the corresponding *pinyin* in brackets, unless the *pinyin* could not be confirmed. Many productions were also referred to by different titles across sources. When this occurs, the thesis consistently uses the title first adopted in the text and explains alternative titles in a footnote whenever they appear in quoted materials.

CHAPTER ONE: A CHINESE SCHOOL WITHIN

> Once one gives up fixed seating and the bifurcation of space, entirely new relationships are possible. Body contact can naturally occur between performers and audience… a sense of shared experience can be engendered
>
> —Richard Schechner

> China also needs to escape from the rut of pseudo-classic formalism into which she had fallen as the result of a too inert traditionalism. At the same time China should not in its eagerness to become progressive imitate the Occident and pour out the baby with the bath water. It should be careful, in short, however much it repudiates the mere formalism, to retain the soul of truth that is contained in its great traditions. When one examines these great traditions one finds certain striking analogies with our Western traditions…
>
> —Irving Babbitt

On a stormy night on May 10th, 1907, eight men of Yale Chinese Students' Club staged the first play organized by Chinese oversea students in American universities that was recorded in the newspaper. Although the performance was filled with only a "small number of students in the audience," it was praised as "one of the most gratifying events of the college year" by an anonymous Yale reporter.[37] The play, *Our Old Happy School Days,* along with a whole performance program, showed something unheard of by the American audiences. On the performance day, the entire hall "was transformed … into something rich and strange that was very interesting and delightfully entertaining… eHavy read [sic] and gold draperies were hung around the stage and from the edges of the gallery were suspended many Chinese lanterns and pictures." As a performance program for the benefit of the Famine sufferers in China, it opened with a speech explaining the great need for famine relief and a couple of numbers by the Yale Orchestra. Then, the program continues to a stereopticon lecture "A Trip through Peking", following a monologue entitled "My Funny Experiences in America," where W.E. Fay humorously described his struggles with American customs and his misfortunes in learning

[37] "Appreciation of Chinese Show," *Yale Daily News* (New Haven, CT), May 11, 1907, 1.

Yale Daily News

VOL. XXX, NO. 170. NEW HAVEN, CONN., FRIDAY, MAY 10, 1907. PRICE THREE CENTS.

CLOSE PRINCETON MEET PROPHESIED

TRACK TEAM LEAVES TODAY FOR TRENTON.

Yale Should Come Out Ahead by the Narrow Margin of 54-50 Points—Strengths and Weaknesses of Each Team Supplement Each Other—Yale Depending on Field Events.

The Yale University Track Team will leave New Haven today on the Colonial Express at 1:05 for Trenton, in anticipation of the annual dual track meet with Princeton at Princeton tomorrow afternoon. The following squad of thirty-one men will report at the station for the above train, and get suits before leaving at the Co-op.: R. B. Bureh, R. L. Twitchell, L. B. Stevens, W. T. Coholan, J. Stillwell, L. V. Howe, C. M. Du Puy, G. V. Thompson, C. H. Davis, V. V. Tilson, S. D. Frissell, E. B. Parsons, R. A. Spitzer, J. F. Williams, B. H. Woodward, D. W. Porter, G. Borup, W. F. Knox, C. D. Deming, L. E. Sisson, G. L. Buhrman, M. O. Sheldon, R. Abbott, R. Park, J. G. George, L. H. Biglow, W. R. Dray, H. Linn, J. W. Murphy, C. Campbell, W. P. Roberts.

Last year Yale won easily by the large score of 78¾ points to 25¼ for Princeton. This year no such win is expected. In fact, it will be by only the hardest kind of a fight that the Yale Team will pull out. Princeton's fine showing against Cornell augurs one of the most hotly contested dual meets ever held between the two universities. For the past number of years the contest with Princeton has always been conceded to Yale without a second thought, as Princeton has generally had second-rate teams. This year, however, the material that Coach Copeland has had to work with has been the best in many years and a strong, although unevenly balanced, team has been developed. Where Yale is strong, Princeton is weak, and vice-versa. It is this interjoining that will even things up, so that by a liberal estimate Yale is given the games by a scant 4 points.

In track games the unexpected often, or usually, happens. A strained tendon or an overturned hurdle may as likely as not bring about a complete change in the final result. Should Princeton take first place in some of the events given to Yale in the following outlook she might easily win.

Princeton will be strong in both the 100-yard dash and the 220-yard dash, with S. Rulon-Miller, who should capture first in each event. Yale will depend on R. L. Twitchell, 1907; R. B. Burch, 1909, and L. B. Stevens, 1908 L. S. D. J. Torrey will not compete.

The 440-yard run will bring out a pretty fight between W. T. Coholan, 1907 S., and J. C. Attee of Princeton. Which will win, is a toss-up, but Yale seems to have the advantage.

In the half-mile run, Yale ought to make a strong bid for all three places if E. B. Parsons, 1907, is in shape. V. V. Tilson, 1908, and S. D. Frissell, 1908, are booked for second and third.

In the mile run Yale's chances are centered in R. A. Spitzer, 1909, and J. F. Williams, 1909. Both are good runners and Spitzer is counted on for first place.

The two-mile run will be easily won by J. L. Eisele of Princeton. Yale is weak in this event, B. H. Woodward, 1907, might take second or third.

In the field events, the high jump and pole vault in particular, Yale is counting on to make up any losses elsewhere. Captain J. W. Marshall, 1907 S., and L. E. Sisson, 1907, should win with ease first and second in the high jump.

(Continued on Third Page.)

GRADUATE STUDENTS' CLUB ORGANIZED.

Officers and Executive Committee Elected, as Well as Faculty Advisory Committee.

At a meeting last evening in Healy Library, Herrick Hall, a club for the graduate students of the University was organized. The following officers were elected: Frank N. Freeman, President; Arthur H. Basye, Secretary, and H. P. Fairchild, Treasurer; Chester A. Reids and W. P. McCune, Executive Committee. The Faculty Advisory Committee will consist of the following: Mr. Anson Phelps Stokes, Jr., Secretary of the University; Professor C. H. Judd, Dr. C. H. Walker, Dr. C. B. Tinker and Dr. H. S. Canby.

All graduate students who were not present at the meeting and who desire to become charter members of the club, are requested to notify one of the officers or members of the executive committee.

The purpose of the newly-organized club is to provide a common meeting place for the graduate students. The usual club facilities will be provided, and the new organization should furnish opportunities for social intercourse. In the future, new members will be elected on much the same plan as is used at present in the New York Yale Club, which does not restrict the election of eligible men.

Spanish Club Meeting.

A very important meeting of the Spanish Club will be held next week, the time and place to be announced is Monday's issue, to elect the officers for next year. All the members who have not paid up their annual dues of $2 are requested to do so before the next meeting in order that the financial business may be cleared up before college closes. Dr. Schevill will have some interesting lantern slides, and the possibility of securing a number of lectures for next year will be discussed.

University Notices.

Crew: University—Squad report at 4:30. Walbridge report also.

Freshman—Squad report at 4:10.

Baseball: University—Take the 3:47 train for New York and the 6:25 train at W. 23d Street for Philadelphia: T. Jones, Meyer, Wernecken, Parsons, Sweeney, Camp, Cushman, Kinney, Madden, Clifford, Chapin, Bromar, H. Jones.

Freshman—Practice at 2.

Sheff. Baseball: Captains—Bring subscriptions collected to 82 Wall Street by tomorrow.

1907 S. Civil Engineers—Practice at Sheff. rush lot at 4.

1907 S. Electrical Engineers—Practice at Sheff. rush lot at 1:30.

1908 S. Civil Engineers—See notice in Winchester. Practice at 4.

Record Baseball: First Colloquies—The following report at Scrub Field at 4:15: Pond, Overall, Wright, Bundy, Field, Mann, Knowles, Pierce, Goodell, Holliday, Stanley, MacDuffie, Bradley.

Second Colloquies—Following report at Scrub Field at 4 for game: Hagan, Shepard, Wren, Kellas, Collins, Stewart, Broomhall, Messerly, Lyon, Spaulding.

Class Golf: 1908—Match with 1909. Bundy (2) and Piehhardt (5) report today. Others play off on Monday.

1908 S.—Following men report for match with 1910: Logan, Prout, Quentin, Peek.

1909 S.—Report for match.

University Track—Men whose names appear in today's News get

(Continued on Fourth Page.)

YALE 6, UNIVERSITY OF VIRGINIA 1.

UNIVERSITY NINE DEFEATED SOUTHERNERS BY HEAVY HITTING.

Cushing in the Box Held Visitors to Five Scattered Hits—Yale Obtained Ten Off Fulton—Fielding Features Were Madden's Catch and Double by Camp and Sweeney.

Fresh from her victory over Princeton, 3-2, the day before, the University of Virginia met defeat at the hands of Yale, 6-1, at the Field yesterday. With two exceptions, Madden's fine running catch in the eighth inning and a double play by Camp and Sweeney in the final inning, the fielding on both sides was featureless. There were also many errors, due largely to the heavy condition of the diamond, the slippery ball and field.

Yale won, as she has done so often, on her ability at landing on the ball safely. Fulton was hit ten times, Cushing only five. Fulton struck out four men, while Cushing fanned three. The Southerners hit him freely enough but into a fielder's hand invariably. He fielded well, had good control and pitched speedier ball than in any previous game this season. At critical stages he did not go up in the air as he has been known to do. Fulton pitched fairly effectively but could not stem the tide of Yale's hits.

Virginia's single run was scored in the third. In the first and second innings she had good opportunities at scoring but was prevented by Yale's fine fielding. In the second, for example, Virginia had a player on first and third. The man on first attempted to steal second; Jones threw to Camp, who returned the ball to Jones. He caught the runner off third on his throw to Church. In the third an error by Sweeney and two singles by Walker and Hoff brought in Virginia's only score. The former made three of his team's five hits.

Yale scored her six runs in five different innings. Only two runs were scored in the second, when a single would have brought in at least two more, as the bases were filled when the side was retired. Church started the scoring with the only two-base hit of the game, and singles by Madden and Camp, brought in Church. Cushing was hit by a pitched ball, filling the bases. Chapin hit to left, scoring Madden; but Jones flied out, ending the batting streak.

In the fourth, a base on balls, hit by pitched ball, a sacrifice hit, and a long fly, scored one for Yale. In the fifth, Jones, after reaching third, by his hit and two grounders, crossed the plate on a passed ball. A combination of errors and hits resulted in two more runs, one in the seventh and one in the eighth.

In fielding, Sweeney was again the worst offender with two errors in one inning, one of them only, however, figured in the scoring. Church had one bad throw against him before Williams took his place because he strained a ligament while at bat in the fourth. Kinney played a splendid game, making two put outs and seven assists. In the ninth he made a careless little slip which had no results as far as the score went but which spoiled what would otherwise have been a fine record. Camp was back in the game again at second and made five assists and two outs without fault.

At the bat Chapin led with three singles. There was quite a shakeup in the batting order, and Chapin was first up, with Jones second. Madden hit twice and Camp, Kinney, Jones, Church and Clifford each got one.

(Continued on Third Page.)

TWO BASEBALL COMPARISONS.

Yale, Harvard and Princeton Compared by Dartmouth and Virginia Men.

As Dartmouth has played both Harvard and Yale in baseball this season and the University of Virginia both Princeton and Yale, the following comparisons given are of interest. The value of any baseball comparison is not at all great owing to the fact that many of the conditions, which determine a victory or defeat in baseball, are never similar in any two games. However, they have some value in presenting the impressions of the relative strength of two teams, at which the players of an opposing team naturally arrive.

Coach T. F. McCarthy of the Dartmouth Team gave the following comparison to the News:

"It is a difficult matter to compare two teams so evenly matched as Harvard and Yale are. Yale at the present time is batting a little better than Harvard. In respect to catchers, both Jones and Currier are excellent but Jones has the advantage in batting. I consider Hartford and Meyer very evenly matched in pitching and both have splendid control.

"Yale is unquestionably better in the infield than Harvard and the former's outfield, too, seems to be able to cover more ground than Harvard's and are practically sure of anything which comes within their territory. In baserunning, neither team has the advantage as both Yale and Harvard have men upon whom they can rely for several 'steals' in each game and these prove a great aid to the scoring ability of each team.

"Comparing the teams as a whole, I should say one team was as good as the other and I think the championship struggle will be one of the fiercest seen in many years."

Captain A. S. Walker of the University of Virginia Baseball Team yesterday gave the following comparison of the Yale and Princeton teams:

"Conditions were hardly favorable for a fair comparison of the teams. The weather and the umpire, though possibly not affecting the results of today's game, were factors which did not make the games appear in the same light and so renders a comparison difficult.

"Considering everything—the pitching, fielding and batting—the teams match up well, though Yale appears to have a slight advantage. In pitching, the men who were in the box against us at Princeton were not as good as Cushing. [Henniger did not pitch for Princeton in the game with Virginia.] Behind the bat Yale is without doubt stronger. In Jones the team has an unrivaled catcher. First is weak, as well as second, though the men at short stop and third help to even up the infielders' standing. Princeton's outfield is, as a whole, faster but in their batting ability compare evenly with the Yale team's outfield.

"As the condition of the field was extremely poor today the base running of the teams cannot be compared."

When Mr. W. A. Lambeth, athletic advisor at Virginia, was questioned as to his opinion on the final result of the Yale-Princeton series, he said: "I believe that Yale will win the series with Princeton."

Partial scores of the two games played by Dartmouth are given as follows:

Assists	Princeton 20,	Yale 19
Errors	Princeton 3,	Yale 4
Hits	Princeton 5,	Yale 10
Stolen bases	Princeton 2,	Yale 2
Sacrifice hits	Princeton 1,	Yale 2

Bases on balls—From Princeton 2, from Yale 2.

Left on bases—Princeton 7, Yale 9.

Three-base hit—Princeton.

Two-base hit—Yale.

THE CHINESE ENTERTAINMENT.

FIRST PERFORMANCE THIS EVENING.

For the Benefit of the Famine Sufferers. Stereopticon Views, Monologue and Short Play to be Given.

Tonight and tomorrow evening at 8:15 the Chinese Club of the University will give an entertainment in College Street Hall for the benefit of the famine sufferers in their native land. The University Orchestra will furnish several numbers in addition to the regular program. Tickets can be procured in advance at the Co-op. for $1.50 and $1.

The program will be opened by a speech by F. Yen, 1908 M. S. Then, after a couple of numbers by the Orchestra, C. C. Wang, 1908 S., will give stereopticon views of Pekin. The slides to be used have never been seen in this country before and include such views as the throne room in the imperial palace and the buildings of the Empress Dowager's summer palace.

A feature of the performance is a monologue, entitled "My Funny Experiences in America," by W. E. Fay, 1907.

The second part of the program is the play, "Our Old Happy School Days," written by the students themselves, and representing a Chinese school in session. The general plan of this is as follows: Several pupils come in late and offer their excuses, but the teacher is unrelenting and sets them to work. This does not last long, however, for the pupils are just commencing to play various schoolboy tricks on their master when a note from his wife calls him away. This is the sign for commencing a general disturbance and a number of Chinese games are played. An Oriental wedding with appropriate costumes and all accessories will also be undertaken. Instead of by Z. Z. Zee, 1909 S., the part of the schoolmaster will be taken by H. H. Kung, G. S.

The corrected cast is:

Schoolmaster.....H. H. Kung, G. S.
Monitor.....W. E. Fay, 1907
Pupils..P. C. Chu, 1909; P. Jui, 1909 S.; H. H. Kung, G. S.; C. C. Wang, 1908 S.; F. Yen, 1908 M. S.
Bride..... P. C. Chu, 1909
Bridegroom.....H. H. Kung, G. S.
Maid of Honor.....F. Yen, 1908 M. S.
Best Man.....C. C. Wang, 1908 S.
Musicians ..... P. Jui, 1909 S. and Z. Z. Zee, 1909 S.
Parson.....W. E. Fay, 1907

The musical program to be given by the University Orchestra is as follows:

1. (a) Victory ..... Perry, 1907
   (b) Whoop It Up....Friedman, 1905
2. Andante from Violin Concerto, Mendelssohn
   Mr. Tompkins and Orchestra.
3. Henry VIII Dances.
   (a) Morris Dance.
   (b) Shepherd's Dance.
   (c) Torch Dance.

Class Crew Appointments.

Today's order of class crew rowing hours is as follows:

1907: At 1:50—Blair, Quirk, Gillis, Shields, Downing, Jackson, Rouse.

At 5:10—Crawford, Dummer, Clement, Bruce, Sheffield, Scott, Francis, Paterson.

1908: At 4:10—First Crew.

At 3:10—Third Crew.

At 2:10—Second Crew.

1909: At 4:10—Davidson, Dennis, Nichols, Bunker, Loree, Jones, Mitchell, R. Wright, Graham.

At 5:00—First Crew and Kane, Driscoll, Faust, Seltzer, Hollett, Glover, Cunningham, Lemmon, Cronecker.

Struck out—Princeton 1, Yale 3.

Struck out by Virginia—Princeton 7, Yale 4.

Figure 1. "The Chinese Entertainment," Yale Daily News, May 10, 1907, 1. Clipping by the author from the Yale Daily News Historical Archive.

"your horrible English."[38] The plot of the play is summarized as follows: Several pupils come in late for school and offer their excuses, but the teacher is unrelenting, physically punishing them in the old Chinese school traditions and setting them to work. Not after long, when the pupils tried various schoolboy tricks on their master, a note from his wife calls him away. Then, the Chinese students begin to teach everyone Chinese school lifestyles. The actors presented the ways of reading, writing, reciting, and playing four games, shuttlecock, rod-fencing, spinning Chinese tops and catching-the-fish were played. After that, an old-fashioned wedding, processing through the audience and mounting the stage, where the ceremony is performed.[39] Finally, the program concluded itself with Chinese refreshments and social events.

Our Old Happy School Days presented a typical CST production format: while usually serving as the central attraction, the theatrical piece was often staged as part of a larger program that included multiple forms of performance and exhibition. The aesthetic experience of the play was often inseparable from other elements of the program, such as the decorations of the performance hall, or the music that preceded the play. For example, in January 1920, a group of Chinese students at the University of Illinois restaged Shen Hong's *Rainbow*, a play written in response to the postwar settlement at Versailles, which transferred Germany's former concessions in Shantung [Shandong] 山東 to Japan despite China's participation in World War I on the Allied side. Although Hong clearly expressed his protest over the Treaty of Versailles in the play, he also revealed a sense of unease toward the people's anger and protests in this incident. In the Illinois reproduction, however, the play was followed by an emotional song composed by John F. Staley that left little room for such ambivalence:

> Aloud we cry against this sin,
> Of Shantung's taking from our hearth,

[38] Ibid.
[39] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 2, no. 6 (May 1907): 129.

Protesting true and strong within,
Proclaiming this throughout the earth.
Oh, Shantung, we will strive for thee,
The grasping hand must not succeed,
To tear thee from thy native hearth,
Is sin untold of mortal greed.[40]

The close-knit relationship between CST and the performance programs therefore requires a detailed examination on the programs before we focus on theatrical productions. What were these programs? Why did Chinese students produce these programs? How were these programs received, and how did they shape the reception of CST within? Only when we understand these questions, can we begin our inquiry on the relationship between CST and the production of Chineseness.

Chinese Entertainment Programs

As Jan Stacey Bieler argued, the Chinese students see themselves as both "students and ambassadors" in America.[41] Hoping that by educating Americans the past and present situation of China, they would gain support from America and fixed prejudices. This ambassadorial role was shaped in part by the early twentieth-century Cosmopolitan Club movement, which gathered foreign and American students under the motto "Above all nations is humanity" and encouraged cross-cultural understanding. Influenced and often sponsored by the Cosmopolitan club movement, Chinese students hosted public entertainment programs that were intended to invite the American audiences to imagine a wider conception of Chineseness than the one previously existed.[42] The most common form of the social events is the Chinese Nights, also known as Oriental Nights, China Nights, or International Nights under the model of national nights

[40] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 15, no. 5 (March 1920): 63.
[41] Jan Stacey Bieler, "The Lost Reformers: Chinese Students in the United States from 1906–1931" (MA thesis, Michigan State University, 1994), 76.
[42] Hin Heng Antonio Tang, "The Nation, the Group, the Individual: Towards an Embodied Rhetorical History of Early 20th Century Chinese University Students in America" (PhD diss., University of Wisconsin–Madison, 2019), 156-157.

produced by the Cosmopolitan clubs. Many of the Chinese Nights became very popular, with frequent local newspaper coverage and thousands of attendants. For instance, the Chinese Night hosted by the Chinese Dramatic Club of Illinois in 1917, attended by more than 600 audiences, and was even demanded by the public to deliver a similar program again.[43] Another program hosted by the Intercollegiate Cosmopolitan Club in New York in 1925 reported that the auditorium was filled with "every available seat long before the play started, packing the auditorium to its capacity, with hundreds standing."[44] The Chinese Nights are usually on campuses, scheduled biannually, hosting near the end of each semester.

With the establishment of the new Republic of China succeeding the Qing dynasty in 1912, Chinese students also started to host another major social program known as the Double Ten Celebration, whose primary goal is to celebrate the anniversary of the birth of the new nation of China. The celebration is usually repeated annually near October 10th, the national day of the Republic of China. Although the goal of the Double Ten Celebration is different from the Chinese Nights, the format of its program remained largely unchanged. The Double Ten program could be closed to Americans, with only Chinese students and some Chinese locals joining the celebration. Thus, the location of the celebration varied from campus venues to off-campus church, high schools, hotel rooms, and restaurants. For example, Chinese students of the Ford Motor Company Trade School staged their Double Ten Celebration in Northern high school, away from the university.[45] Despite its goal unrelated to general Americans, Chinese Double Ten Celebration remained a crowded entertainment when it received general audiences, with the

[43] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 12, no. 5 (March 1917): 272–73.
[44] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 20, no. 3 (January 1925): 66–67.
[45] "Play to Show Culture of New China," *Detroit Free Press* (Detroit, MI), October 7, 1925, 12.



Fig. 2**.** *Sorrow in a Chinese Palace*, Double Ten Celebration, 1925, International House New York Archive.

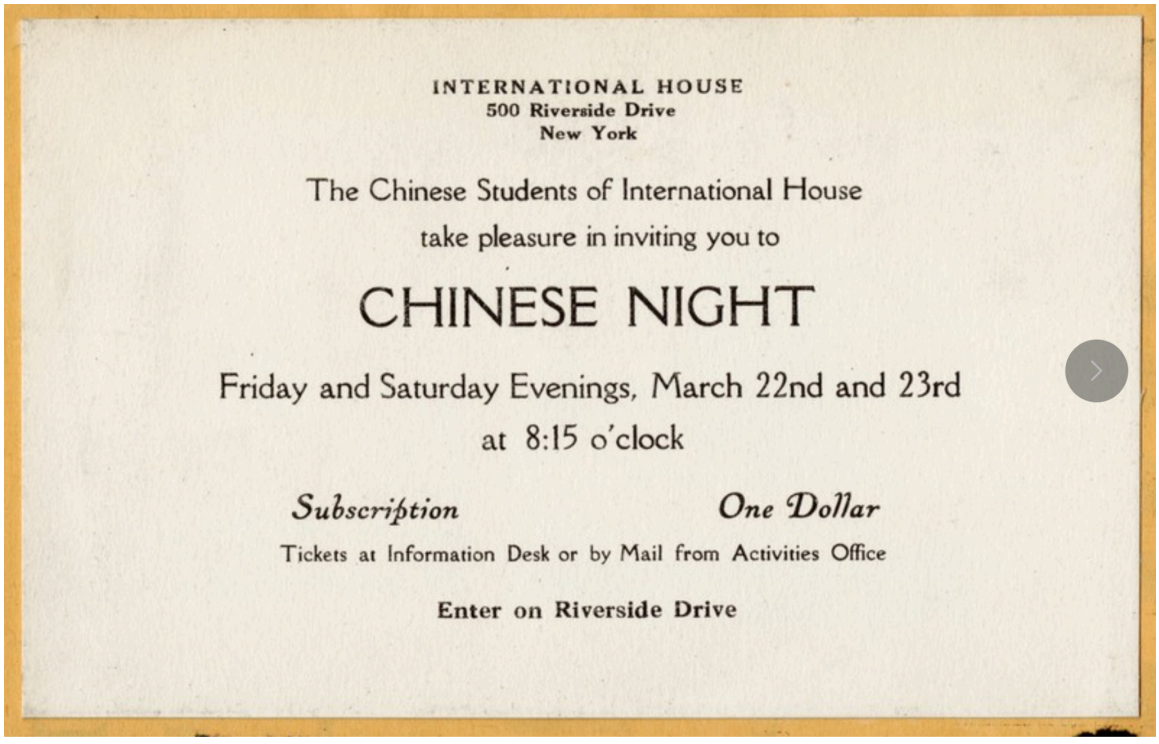


Figure 3. Chinese Night Invitation, 1929, International House New York Archive.

Pittsburg Double Ten Celebration in 1920 filled by 1700 participants.[46]

Another major occasion for Chinese public entertainment programs was fundraising for famine relief. Between 1906 to 1931, two major famines occurred in China: The Kiangpeh famine of 1906-1907 and The northern Chinese famine of 1920-1921. The first marked the beginning of Chinese students hosting social entertainment programs, and the latter led to an outburst of Chinese students' public activities in 1921. While the impact of the 1907 famine relief programs appears to have been limited, likely because there were relatively few Chinese students in the United States at the time, the 1921 programs reached a much broader audience and raised substantial funds. Students traveled to different cities, performing for both American audiences and Chinese merchants, with Chinese officials also traveling overseas to support their efforts. The scale of these efforts can be seen in specific cases: Two performances by the Chinese Students' Club of MIT in January of 1921 yielded $1271.92.[47] The Chinese students of Columbia staged *Mulan* in 1921 from February to May, travelling from New York to New Jersey and New Haven, repeating the production over ten times, with single performances raising over $1800.[48]

A Space of Our Own

Hin Heng Antonio Tang argues that Chinese entertainment programs were social programs that invite American audiences to imagine "a wider conception" of the stereotypical Chineseness.[49] He emphasizes that Chinese students managed themselves in public and, by controlling *what* was presented, sought to display a better image of China to Americans. Tang's

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[46] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 16, no. 2 (December 1920): 154–55.
[47] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 16, no. 7 (May 1921): 533. $1271 is roughly $20,000 in present time.
[48] "Receipts of Chinese Play" *The Montclair Times* (Montclair, NJ), July 16, 1921, 2. $1800 is approximately $30,000 in present time.
[49] Hin Heng Antonio Tang, "The Nation, the Group, the Individual: Towards an Embodied Rhetorical History of Early 20th-Century Chinese University Students in America" (PhD diss., University of Wisconsin–Madison, 2019), 156–57.



Fig. 4. Stage photo of *Mulan*. *Buffalo Courier Express* [Buffalo, NY], 13 Mar. 1921, p. 6.

Newspaper clipping by the author.

description of these entertainment programs as "social programs" offers a valuable way to understand Chinese Nights not merely as public presentations, but as relational events. Expanding on Tang's argument, I propose that Chinese students manage not only themselves, but also their American spectators. Rather than focusing only on what was presented, they established their own rules to emphasize *who* is presenting and *how* it is presented. As Said argues, "Orientalism depends for its strategy on this flexible positional superiority, which puts the Westerner in a whole series of possible relationships with the Orient without ever losing him the relative upper hand."[50] Chinese entertainment programs created a liminal space in which this positional hierarchy could be, at least temporarily, challenged.

The creation of this liminal space began with the control of entry. Many Chinese entertainment programs were invitation-only. Even programs open to the public were often framed as invitations, announcing that "the public is cordially invited."[51] The expression of "I invite you" rather than "you watch me" repositioned Chinese students as subjects rather than objects of spectatorship. In addition, entering a Chinese entertainment program sometimes takes more than an invitation letter or ticket. In 1914, Chinese students of the Greater Boston area presented a play adapted from famous Chinese literature, *See Yue Chee*. As reported by *Boston Evening Transcript,* "No one will be admitted to the fete unless he or she is wearing a Chinese costume and the committee in charge will have on view at Copley Hall."[52] The Chinese students emphasized their position as host, and the message was blunt: You wanna see a Chinese show? Follow our etiquette first!

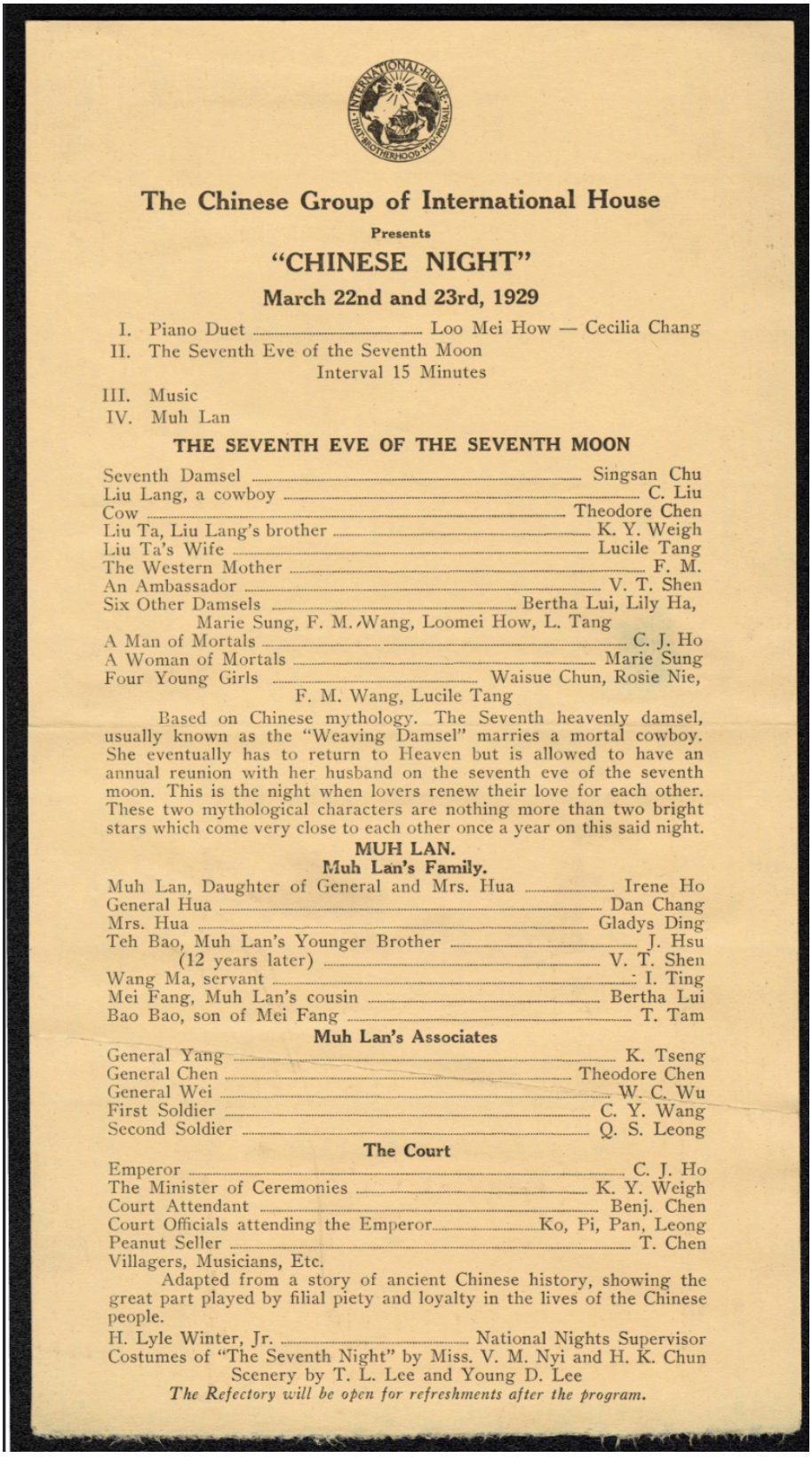
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[50] Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (1978; repr., London: Penguin Books, 2003), 7.
[51] "Depict Schoolroom of Chinese in Play," *The Daily Illini* (Urbana, IL), December 9, 1920, 5; "Cosmopolitan Club to Entertain," *Yale Daily News* (New Haven, CT), April 24, 1923, 2.
[52] "News of the Theatres," *Boston Evening Transcript* (Boston, MA), April 6, 1914, 17.

After being admitted into the performance hall, audiences would watch a complete program arranged in a carefully designed order. Chinese entertainment programs usually began with several speeches or lectures by Chinese students and invited professors, followed by lantern slides showing images of China, before reaching the main entertainment: Chinese music, magic, martial arts, and plays. After the performance, Chinese refreshments would be served, while all participants would be socializing with each other. Despite their names, the Chinese students designed these programs not simply as entertainment programs, but as educational programs. Performances were often accompanied by explanatory programs, and exhibitions of Chinese objects were supplemented by explanations. American audiences were also asked to participate bodily in Chinese practices: at Illinois, for example, a Chinese opera was "sung by an American," while at the University of Missouri guests were taught to use "chopsticks ... instead of knives and forks" to enjoy Chinese food.[53] The Chinese students asserted their position as teachers, as the ones who could define what China was and how it should be understood.

All of the audiences seeing Chinese entertainment programs will immediately be struck by the disappearance of the original space. The performance space of *See Yue Chi* was described as "artistically decorated," Chinese decorative things covering "over the balconies, under the roof, upon the benches and along the walls-every-where."[54] The transformation was of the entire space, and it nearly produced the illusion of a return to a Chinese space. *Boston Post* described another Chinese Famine relief program in 1921 as: "A splendid effort was made to preserve as nearly as possible the atmosphere of the Chinese theatre as it exists in China. The music, the decorations, the costumes, the entire setting were entirely Oriental."[55] As *The Capital Times*

[53] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 16, no. 5 (March 1921): 299; *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 20, no. 6 (April 1925): 74.
[54] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 9, no. 7 (May 1914): 562.
[55] *Boston Post* (Boston, MA), January 31, 1921, 5.



The Chinese Group of International House

Presents

"CHINESE NIGHT"

March 22nd and 23rd, 1929

I. Piano Duet ..... Loo Mei How — Cecilia Chang
II. The Seventh Eve of the Seventh Moon
Interval 15 Minutes
III. Music
IV. Muh Lan

THE SEVENTH EVE OF THE SEVENTH MOON

Seventh Damsel ..... Singsan Chu
Liu Lang, a cowboy ..... C. Liu
Cow ..... Theodore Chen
Liu Ta, Liu Lang's brother ..... K. Y. Weigh
Liu Ta's Wife ..... Lucile Tang
The Western Mother ..... F. M.
An Ambassador ..... V. T. Shen
Six Other Damsels ..... Bertha Lui, Lily Ha,
Marie Sung, F. M. Wang, Loomei How, L. Tang
A Man of Mortals ..... C. J. Ho
A Woman of Mortals ..... Marie Sung
Four Young Girls ..... Waisue Chun, Rosie Nie,
F. M. Wang, Lucile Tang

Based on Chinese mythology. The Seventh heavenly damsel, usually known as the "Weaving Damsel" marries a mortal cowboy. She eventually has to return to Heaven but is allowed to have an annual reunion with her husband on the seventh eve of the seventh moon. This is the night when lovers renew their love for each other. These two mythological characters are nothing more than two bright stars which come very close to each other once a year on this said night.

MUH LAN.

Muh Lan's Family.

Muh Lan, Daughter of General and Mrs. Hua ..... Irene Ho
General Hua ..... Dan Chang
Mrs. Hua ..... Gladys Ding
Teh Bao, Muh Lan's Younger Brother ..... J. Hsu
(12 years later) ..... V. T. Shen
Wang Ma, servant ..... I. Ting
Mei Fang, Muh Lan's cousin ..... Bertha Lui
Bao Bao, son of Mei Fang ..... T. Tam

Muh Lan's Associates

General Yang ..... K. Tseng
General Chen ..... Theodore Chen
General Wei ..... W. C. Wu
First Soldier ..... C. Y. Wang
Second Soldier ..... Q. S. Leong

The Court

Emperor ..... C. J. Ho
The Minister of Ceremonies ..... K. Y. Weigh
Court Attendant ..... Benj. Chen
Court Officials attending the Emperor ..... Ko, Pi, Pan, Leong
Peanut Seller ..... T. Chen
Villagers, Musicians, Etc.

Adapted from a story of ancient Chinese history, showing the great part played by filial piety and loyalty in the lives of the Chinese people.

H. Lyle Winter, Jr. ..... National Nights Supervisor
Costumes of "The Seventh Night" by Miss. V. M. Nyi and H. K. Chun
Scenery by T. L. Lee and Young D. Lee

The Refectory will be open for refreshments after the program.

Fig. 5. *Chinese Night Program*, 1929, International House New York Archive.

reported of a Chinese festival held by Wisconsin–Madison students in 1923, "On the strains of weird, high-strung music, oriental music that called up dim pictures of jade and burning joss sticks, a delighted audience spent two enchanted hours in far-away, mystic China."[56] Through this "splendid effort" to transform Western spaces, Chinese students created a temporary space of their own, an ordinary Western place devoured by Chineseness.

Not all Americans were comfortable sitting through these entertainment programs. The *Boston Evening Transcript* described the requirement that guests wear Chinese costumes to watch *See Yue Chee* with a sarcastic remark: the illustrated examples of Chinese dress were "as Chinese doubtless as the little circular announcing the occasion." A similar discomfort appeared in a report on the Chinese Students' Club of Pittsburgh's production of *The Rising Giant*. The newspaper complained that "'On with the play' was not the slogan" of the evening, since American audiences did not expect to sit through all the speeches and preliminary performances before the play began. The writer concluded that "the theater customs of Americans meant nothing to the Chinese students."[57] These complaints reveal the tension produced when Chinese students replaced familiar American expectations with their own rules. The very irritation of American audiences shows that Chinese students had succeeded in reversing the preexisting power relationship between the East and the West. In this reversal, Chinese students became the host, the teachers, and the source of the Chinese knowledge.

A Shared Space

The repositioning of China within American society through student entertainment programs did not rely solely on claiming ownership over the space; it also depended on a restructuring of the performance space to create a new relationship between the spectators and

[56] *The Capital Times* (Madison, WI), April 30, 1923, 2.
[57] *Pittsburgh Post-Gazette* (Pittsburgh, PA), October 12, 1920, 13.

actors, the Chinese and the American. In many Chinese performances, the place of performances was not confined to the orthodox stage, but took over the entire hall. In a production staged by Chinese members of the International House of New York on Halloween night in 1925, for example, the play *The Chinese Ghost Land* unfolded alongside a fortune-teller's booth in the auditorium run by Miss Dorothy Wong, the current editor of *CSM*, who answered questions from curious audience members.[58]

The restructuring of the performance space allows us to reconsider the changing relations among performers, audiences, and space that ultimately disrupt Orientalism. It transformed the pre-existing spatial model of Chinese theatres in America, the Orientalist proscenium model. As Said argues, "The Orient is the stage on which the whole East is confined … The Orient then seems to be, not an unlimited extension beyond the familiar European world, but rather a closed field, a theatrical stage affixed to Europe."[59] Said's description of a "stage affixed to Europe" is clearly referring to a proscenium stage. Although Said uses theatre here metaphorically, it maps perfectly into the literal 19th and early 20th century American theatres that perform Chinese themes. The viewing mode of these proscenium stages sustained Orientalism in two ways: First, it placed Americans as the subject and Chinese as the objects under gaze. It positioned the American audiences from the outside, and reduced Chinese bodies and objects into representative signs. Second, the fourth wall of the proscenium stage provided an imaginary border. By separating the Chinese from the American audiences, it enabled the Americans to imagine themselves as culturally and racially distinct from those on stage.

If a proscenium stage reinforces Orientalism, then how does restructuring of performance space disrupt this logic? Let us return to *Our Old Happy School Days*, the play with which this

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[58] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 21, no. 3 (January 1926): 68.
[59] Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (1978; repr., London: Penguin Books, 2003), 63.

chapter began. During the play, the performance repeatedly reconfigured its spatial arrangement, moving between the designated stage and the auditorium and transforming them into a classroom, a playground, and a wedding space. When the teachers are called away, the Chinese students on stage begin to teach Chinese games to the audience. As one newspaper reported, the "school becomes a moment… play-ground and Chinese games are introduced."[60] At this point, space is no longer divided between performers and spectators, but turns into a shared space of play and learning. The audience no longer remains seated as detached observers, but becomes part of the activity itself.

After the Chinese game, the wedding ceremony began, with the bride and groom entering from the auditorium, making the audience both the spectators of the performance and the participants of the Chinese wedding. When the couple arrived on the stage, everyone waited nervously until "at the proper moment the bridegroom tenderly lifted the veil from the face of the bride and disclosed the Oriental face of P. C. Chu of the sophomore class."[61] Notice the almost paradoxical use of "Oriental face of P. C. Chu" and "sophomore class" here. On the one hand, the racialized description of P. C. Chu as "Oriental" allows the audience to imagine the wedding as distant and different. Yet that imagination is immediately interrupted by the reminder that this face belongs to "P. C. Chu of the sophomore class," someone situated among them. The same dialectic is inscribed in the wedding ceremony, as the repeatedly shifting spatial arrangement pushes against the orthodox stage of Chinese representation and produces a new relationship between audience and performers. As Schechner argues, "once one gives up fixed seating and the bifurcation of space, entirely new relationships are possible. Body contact can naturally occur

[60] "The Chinese Play," *The Morning Journal-Courier* (New Haven, CT), May 11, 1907, 8.
[61] Ibid.

between performers and audience… a sense of shared experience can be engendered."[62] As the wedding progressed, the fourth wall collapsed, and the hall became a shared space of Yale students. Thus, in the newspaper report the second day, the Chinese students were praised for exemplifying the Yale spirit "which many undergraduates who talk loudly of the Yale spirit —but never show— it may well contemplate."[63] Through reorganizing the performance space, Chinese students have challenged Orientalism through establishing a shared space with the fellow American students.

School, Confucianism, and Nostalgia

Whether establishing a space of their own or creating a shared space with American audiences, Chinese students drew upon the idea of the "school" frequently in their public entertainment programs. In the former, they created a school within American universities that taught and shared knowledge of Chinese culture. In the latter, they established a shared space through a common identity as students, which bridged the divide between Chinese performers and American audiences. "School" played three major roles in the Chinese students' life: First, they were physically staying in schools, and American intellectuals were their immediate audiences. Second, schools are the place where cultural knowledge was produced, transmitted, and contested. Third, attending school constituted the most significant shared experience among Chinese students. Possibly due to the importance of "school" in the Chinese students' life, many CST performances were directly about "school."[64]

One of the frequent themes in these "school plays" was the encounter between Chinese and Western values within educational settings. This encounter often took the form of

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[62] Richard Schechner, "6 Axioms for Environmental Theatre," *The Drama Review: TDR* 12, no. 3 (Spring 1968): 49.
[63] "Appreciation of Chinese Show," *Yale Daily News* (New Haven, CT), May 11, 1907, 1.
[64] Table 1 lists all "school plays" between 1906-1931.

Table 1, *CIST school plays, 1906–1931*

Play	Time	Troupe	Location	Patronage	Author
Our Old Happy School Days	1907	Yale Chinese Students' Club	College Street Hall	General public	N/A
A Chinese School	1907	Harvard Chinese students	Harvard Union	General public	T. C. Ma
When the East and the West Meet	1910	Pennsylvania Chinese Students' Club	Houston Hall	General public	N/A
N/A	1911	Chinese Women's Club for Mutual Encouragement in New York City	New York City	General public	Yu Jung Chang
Chinese School Life	1913	Yale Chinese students	Yale University	General public	N/A
When the Old Meets the New	1914	Chinese Students in Philadelphia	University of Philadelphia	General public	N/A
Kultur vs. Democracy	1919	Grinnell Chinese Students' Club	Grinnell College	Students at Grinnell College	H. C. Chen
Between Smiles and Tears	1920	Chinese Students of Wisconsin–Madison	Lathrop Hall	General public	M. H. Chow
The Old School Day	1920	Pittsburg Chinese Student Club	Pennsylvania, Wilkinsburg, Methodist Episcopal Church	General public	M. H. Chow
China Past and Present	1920	Illinois Chinese Students' Club	Morrow Hall	General public	C. C. Yu

Confucianism, which had long served as the foundation of Chinese educational traditions, confronting American values. The recurring dialectic between Confucianism and Western teachings had started in the Late Qing. Beginning with the *bairi weixin* (Hundred Days' Reform) 百日維新 of 1898, during which reformers sought to reinterpret Confucianism to justify political and educational reforms, Confucian traditions were increasingly challenged by Western modernity. New-style school system under the late Qing reforms (1901–1911) was established, and the *keju zhidu* (imperial examination system) 科舉制度 was abolished in 1905.[65]

Although Confucianism was increasingly challenged by Western knowledge, Chinese intellectuals also sought to reinterpret Confucian traditions by incorporating elements of Western culture. One early example was the adaptation of the *jikong* (Confucius worship) 祭孔 ceremony in Shanghai's new-style schools. Traditionally, the *jikong* ceremony was a ritual of reverence for Confucius as China's great sage and teacher, performed through rites, music, and dances across the Chinese empire. By the late Qing, a few new-style schools in Shanghai adapted the *jikong* ceremony by integrating Western theatrical performances into the ritual. These adaptations, according to Joshua Chung, were a response to the Christian missionary schools in Shanghai that staged plays on Western holidays. He argues:

> Based on a strong sense of cultural resistance, late Qing literati had proposed using either the Yellow Emperor or Confucius as the starting point for dating years, in order to "stand against" the Western calendar, which counted years from the birth of Jesus. When Shanghai students staged new plays on Confucius's birthday in the name of "celebrating the sage," they were, on the one hand, imitating the practice of Christian missionary schools that staged plays to celebrate Christmas Eve. On the other hand, there was also a sense of rivalry in this practice.[66]

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[65] The Late Qing Reforms (1901-1911) were a series of modernization efforts initiated by Empress Cixi. During the period, the Qing government trained new armies, abolished the civil service exam, and attempted a transition to a constitutional monarchy.

[66] "基於強烈的文化抵抗意識,晚清文人分別主張過以黃帝或孔子 紀年「抗衡」西方國家以耶穌降世為準的西元紀年。當上海學生以「祝聖」的名 義在孔誕日排演新劇時,一方面是模仿教會學校在西洋聖誕夜演劇慶祝的做法, 一方面也不無互別苗頭的意味。" Joscha Chung, "Students' Theatrical

Although no direct connection can be established between the adaptations of the *jikong* ceremony and Chinese student entertainment programs in America, the theatrical presentation of Confucianism in CST similarly served as a form of cultural resistance.

In 1911, the Chinese Women's Club for Mutual Encouragement in New York City staged the first publicly performed play organized and written by Chinese female students in America. Written by Yu Jung Chang, the play follows a Chinese girl who dreams of America and receives the opportunity to study there. Although America appears as a space of possibility, her departure from China is also painful. During the farewell dinner, she bows to her mother, who mournfully says, "I am afraid," and then bows to her horrified relatives, who believe she is "going to her destruction." The next scene shifts to an American college, where the heroine encounters parties, sports, and lively student culture, but remains committed to her studies. When another Chinese girl, who has been led astray by American manners, can no longer translate Chinese and speaks slang like a native, the heroine comforts her by saying that "in your heart you are still a true Chinese girl." The play ends with both girls returning home, weeping joyfully among their families, and singing *Shall Dear Old China Be Forgot* to the tune of *Auld Lang Syne*.[67] Another public entertainment program, staged at the University of Wisconsin–Madison in 1920, opened with W. H. Chiao's address, "The Chinese Ideal of Democracy," in which he argued that democratic principles were not exclusively Western but had existed in Chinese thought for thousands of years through Confucian teachings. The program then featured various

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Activities in Late Qing and the Beginning of Modern Chinese Theatre" [晚清新知識空間裏的學生演劇與中國現代劇場的緣起], *Journal of Theater Studies* 8 (July 2011): 31-32.

[67] "Chinese Act For Charity," *New-York Tribune* (New York, NY), December 12, 1911, 9.

representations of Chinese cultural practices and concluded with *Between Smiles and Tears*, a Chinese schoolroom scene "depicting the happy hours of old Chinese school life."[68]

These performances suggest two strategies that Chinese students adopted to resist the assumption of Western cultural superiority. First, Chinese values were articulated through familiar Western concepts and cultural forms. In the Wisconsin Chinese Night, Chiao's speech reframed Confucian teachings through the language of the West, challenging the notion that democratic ideals were exclusively Western inventions. As *The Capital Times* reported, "The West came away from the entertainment wiser and less cocksure of itself," having learned that principles associated with American democracy had supposedly existed in China for thousands of years. Similarly, in Yu Jung Chang's play, *Shall Dear Old China Be Forgot* adapted the familiar Scottish melody of *Auld Lang Syne* to express Chinese students' attachment to their families and homeland. The play affirms a Confucian moral structure centered on filial attachment to family and loyalty to China through the appropriation of Western musical form.

Tang interprets this practice as Chinese students' engagement in "limited assimilation" as a way of "mitigating negative impressions of Chinese." In his writing, Tang accurately captures the "in-between" position of Chinese students, showing how they were both eager to integrate into American society and resistant to full assimilation. As Tang argues, Chinese students understood integration as necessary for challenging the image of the segregated "Chinaman," yet they also worried that such integration might signal a betrayal of their motherland.[69] However, I would disagree with Tang's usage of "limited assimilation," as the phrase suggests a partial adjustment toward the American norms and ignores the Chinese students' agency in selectively acquiring materials from the dominant culture. Instead, I would propose to understand the public

[68] "West Meets Orient in Madison Fete; Hear Democracy Is Old, Old Idea," *The Capital Times* (Madison, WI), April 23, 1920; *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 15, no. 8 (June 1920).
[69] Tang, "The Nation, the Group, the Individual": 151–56.

entertainment programs as Mary Louise Pratts's "autoethnographic text," where the marginal group represent themselves through a "selective collaboration with and appropriation of idioms of the metropolis or the conqueror."[70] It is through these autoethnographic performances that Bhabha's "third space," a space of "cultural hybridity" emerges: a space in which cultural signs are continually "appropriated, translated, rehistoricized, and read anew," thereby resisting the fixity or exoticism of Orientalism.[71]

Second, Chinese students' representations of traditional school life evoked a sense of nostalgia that both fostered a shared identity among Chinese students and served as a form of cultural resistance through *pathos*. Coming from different regions of China, these students did not necessarily share the same customs or even understand each other's dialect.[72] Yet their common experiences of Chinese schools provided a place through which they could imagine a collective identity. The recurring nostalgia for school life is evident in the titles of several performances, including *Our Old Happy School Days*, *Between Smiles and Tears*, and *The Old School Days*. These plays transformed the Chinese school that many students had left behind into a shared experience that preserved and reaffirmed Chinese identity in America. By presenting Chinese schoolrooms before American audiences, the Chinese students constructed a powerful nostalgia that strongly resisted Americanization.

While Confucianism was often presented in confrontation with Western values in CST, it was also portrayed as an equal counterpart capable of working alongside them toward a better world. In 1910, the Chinese students of Pennsylvania University held a Chinese Night, during

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[70] Mary Louise Pratt, "Arts of the Contact Zone," *Profession* (1991): 36.
[71] Homi K. Bhabha, *The Location of Culture* (London: Routledge, 1994): 37.
[72] English had to be used as official speaking language during the Chinese Students Alliance Summer Conferences because of the different regional dialects Chinese students spoke. See Weili Ye, Seeking Modernity in China's Name: Chinese Students in the United States, 1900–1927 (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2001), 28.

which they presented a play called *When the East and the West Meet*. The program opened with a remark by T.C.F. Quo, who spoke with "an intense loyalty to his country," commented on the failure of American lifestyles in humorous ways but asserted that one day Chinese and the United States should meet peacefully.[73] The play that followed was written by the students themselves and contrasted life in the West with Confucian teachings. In the first act, the scene was set in a traditional Confucian school, where a teacher conversed with the father of one of his students, and the two made fun of foreigners in China. In the second act, the setting shifted to an American boarding house, where the play portrayed various aspects of Chinese students' experiences in the United States, including interactions with an Irish landlord, participation in modern college sports, and the challenges of adjusting to life at an American university. Notably, while the play emphasized the differences between Western values and Confucian teachings through these humorous plots, it concluded with a vision of peaceful coexistence between the two cultures. Implicit in this vision was the possibility of maintaining cultural differences while achieving mutual understanding. This idea was also reflected in the scenic design of the performance space: "At one end of the hall hung an immense Chinese flag, while directly opposite the Stars and Stripes waved in salute to the lone dragon."[74] Such arrangement made the performance space appear equally divided between China and the United States, while the image of the American flag "salut[ing]" the Chinese dragon suggested recognition between the two countries. Rather than accepting Americanization, the play suggested that Chinese and American values should coexist as equal.

Four years later, Chinese students at the University of Pennsylvania staged another play titled *When the Old Meet the New* as part of their annual Chinese Night program. Although no

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[73] Ibid.
[74] "'Chinese Night' Big Hit," *The Pennsylvanian* 25, no. 128 (Philadelphia, PA), March 10, 1910, 1.

detailed plot summary survives, the *CSM* report offers a glimpse into the play's characters and themes. Set within a "typical modern Chinese family," the play featured a traditional patriarch, his foreign-educated son, a daughter, a family tutor, and a servant. The tutor, played by J. V. Ly, delivered an exposition of Confucius's doctrine of "universal peace." Meanwhile, the servant, played by K. H. Li illustrated "the new attitude of the Chinese people toward menial service." Particularly striking was the daughter, played by Miss V. K. Ho, whose "almost Pankhurstine enunciations" received enthusiastic applause.[75]

How, then, did the "old" meet the "new" in this "typical modern Chinese family"? The play suggests that Confucianism was a tradition capable of accommodating modern social values. The tutor's exposition of Confucius's doctrine of "universal peace" may be understood in relation to *tianxia datong* (Universal Great Unity) 天下大同, a Confucian ideal that had been radically reinterpreted by reformers such as Youwei Kang 康有為. As Albert H. Y. Chen explains, Kang drew upon classical Confucian thought while incorporating elements of modern political and social philosophy.[76] Kang argues that

> …Universal peace and great unity…My way to salvation is to break through the nine boundaries.
> First, abolish national boundaries to unite the entire world.
> Second, abolish class boundaries to establish equality among ethnicities.
> Third, abolish racial boundaries to unite all humanity.
> Fourth, abolish gender boundaries to safeguard individual independence.
> …
> Seventh, abolish the boundaries of disorder to establish universal peace.[77]

In the play, the tutor articulated a form of Confucianism that was reinterpreted through Western modernity,

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[75] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 10, no. 5 (March 1915): 323.

[76] Albert H. Y. Chen, "The Concept of 'Datong' in Chinese Philosophy as an Expression of the Idea of the Common Good," in *The Common Good: Chinese and American Perspectives*, ed. P. C. Lo and David Solomon (Dordrecht: Springer, 2014), 85.

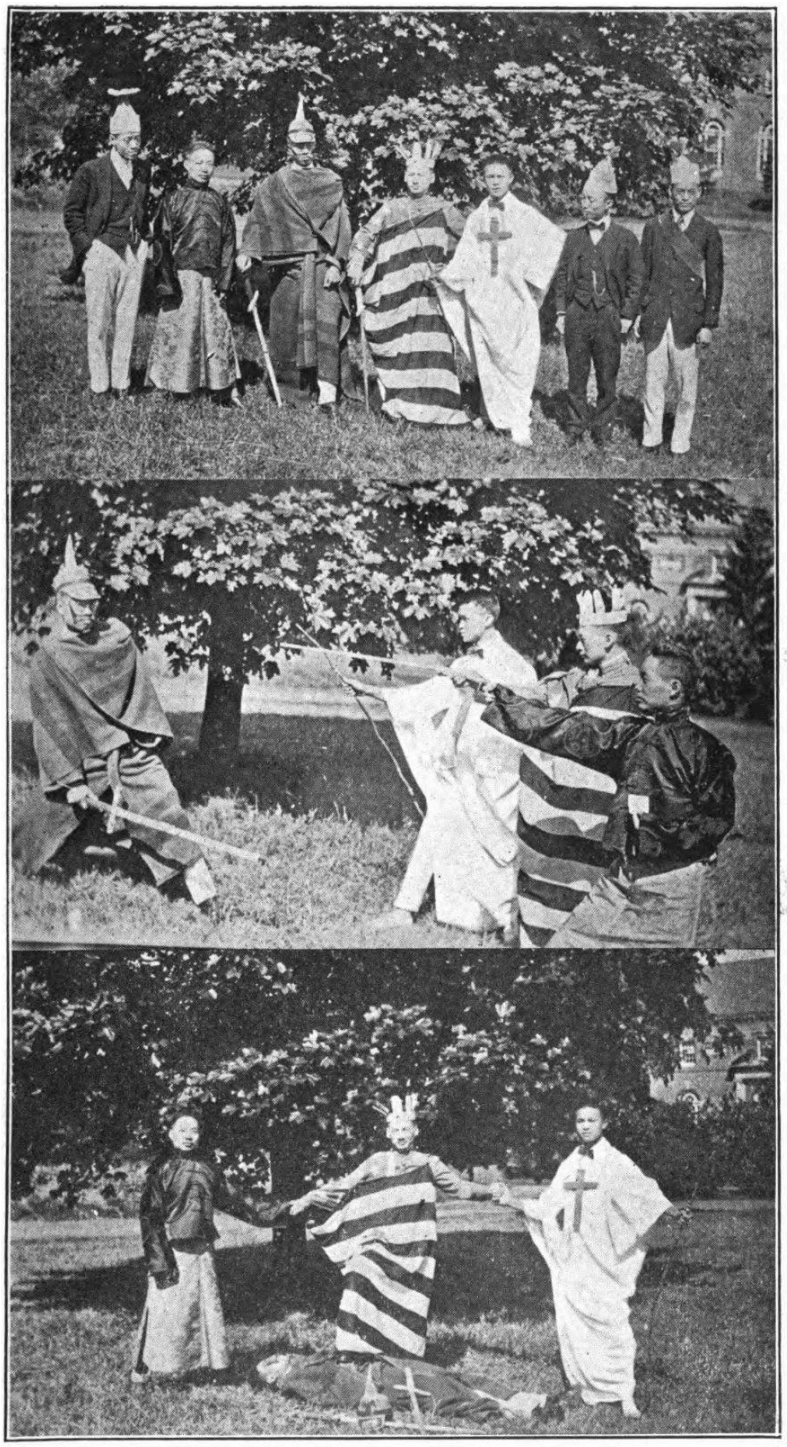
[77] …太平大同...吾救苦之道，卽在破除九界而已。第一曰去國界，合大地也；第二曰去級界，平民族也；第三曰去種界，同人類也；第四曰去形界，保獨立也；第五曰去家界，爲天民也；第六曰去產界，公生業也；第七曰去亂界，治太平也；第八曰去類界，愛衆生也；第九曰去苦界，至極樂也。Youwei Kang, Datong shu 大同書 [The Book of Great Unity], ed. Qian Ding'an 錢定安 (Shanghai: Zhonghua Shuju, 1935), part 1, "Ru shijie guan zhong ku" 入世界觀眾苦.

affirming that traditional Confucian teachings could be applied to modern lives. The reviewer's comparison of the daughter to British suffragette leader Emmeline Pankhurst suggests that her expressions of female independence resonated with contemporary Western feminist discourse. Yet such ideals were not exclusive to the West, as Kang had similarly advocated the abolition of "gender boundaries" in his vision of *datong*. Rather than presenting Chinese traditions and Western values as opposing forces, the play brought them together within the same household, again suggesting that both could contribute to modernity.

The vision of a shared contribution peaked in the subsequent play, *Kultur vs. Democracy* that premiered in 1918 during the Northfield Students Conference organized by the Young Men's Christian Association(YMCA). Written under the context of World War I by H. C. Chen, the play included four allegorical characters: Kultur, Democracy, Confucianism, and Christianity. The German term *Kultur* directly translates to "culture," yet during World War I, German intellectuals invoked the concept to justify Germany's war effort, portraying German *Kultur* superior to Russian autocracy and Western materialism. In Allied propaganda, however, the term had been associated with German militarism and an opposition to democracy. The play began with Kultur jumping onto the stage and declaring his intention to "dominate every spot under the sun with Germanic power and to bless the world with the dominion of autocracy."[78] Democracy and Christianity then appeared and confronted Kultur. When Confucianism finally appeared, Kultur greeted him as a friend. Confucianism rejected and declared his allegiance to Democracy and Christianity. In response, Kultur insisted that whoever possessed the greatest might would ultimately prevail. However, Christianity, Democracy, and Confucianism joined forces and overpowered him. After the stage combat, the three characters began discussing how they would reconstruct the world, and Democracy declared:

> DEMOCRACY. Yes, let us give to every nationality liberty and independence. Let us create a league of all nations to enforce peace and to guard against any recurrence of second Kultur and Militarism. (Speaking to Christianity.) Hitherto, thou has rendered service to individuals; henceforth, thou must also govern our international relations;

[78] *The Chinese Students' Christian Journal* 5, no. 1 (November 1918), 57.



I.—PERSONNEL
II.—THE FIGHT
III.—THE DOWNFALL OF KULTUR
NOTE:—*For contents of play see page* 56-58.

Figure 6. Performance of Kultur vs. Democracy, 1918. Author's clipping from *The Chinese Students' Christian Journal* 5, no. 1 (November 1918), 33.

> forever, thou must abide with us all. (Speaking to Confucianism.) Thou too hast a place in the reconstruction of the world. With thy philosophy and ethics, come! We welcome thee. (Speaking to both.) In the name of God, and Humanity, let us work together and join hand in hand for the coming of the Kingdom of Heaven on earth.[79]

Chinese students' vision of a cosmopolitan future in which Confucianism and Western values could work "hand in hand" was fully realized on stage through this Christian morality drama style play. Through these theatrical works, the Chinese students showed the Americans their willingness and capability to play an equal part on the world stage.

Summary

In this chapter, I have explored the Chinese students' public entertainment programs and a specific type of CST, the school plays. Through both their space-making activities and staging Confucianism, Chinese students challenged Western cultural dominance as well as expressed their genuine desire for an equal and friendly relationship with Americans. Free from the commercial pressures of professional theatre, the university environment provided Chinese students with a space for theatrical experimentation and intellectual debate. Within this space, they sought to resist the positional superiority of the West through both the *logos* of the new Confucianism and the *pathos* of nostalgic representations of Chinese school life. Through these "Chinese schools" established within American institutions, Chinese students sought to redefine Chineseness on their own terms by reimagining various relationships between East and West.

Although Chinese students repeatedly expressed their hopes for a cosmopolitan future, their wishes were soon devastated. Linson Edward Dzau 曹霖生, who played Democracy in *Kultur vs. Democracy*, would soon discover that the ideals he had proclaimed onstage were little more than a vain imagination. Serving as a secretary to the Chinese delegation at the 1919 Paris Peace Conference, he witnessed firsthand the Shandong Question, as Germany's former rights

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[79] *Ibid.*, 60.

and privileges in Shandong were transferred to Japan, from one imperial power to another. Although many Chinese students did not give up cosmopolitanism, the image of Confucianism and Western values walking "hand in hand" no longer appeared onstage in the performances examined after 1920. Chinese students increasingly turned their attention to more specific questions of modernity, particularly those concerning their personal life, while showing less attention to the ideal of a universal peace. In 1920, Hong Shen wrote a play titled *For Romeo and Juliet*, centering on the problems of modern Chinese marriage. The play concluded with an exchange in which one character invoked President Woodrow Wilson's famous declaration, "We must make the world safe for democracy." Another character responded sarcastically, "But first, let us make China safe—for Romeo and Juliet!"[80] Therefore, next chapter we will turn to another question, the presentation of Chinese weddings on the American stage.

[80] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 15, no. 7 (May 1920): 53.

CHAPTER TWO: THE WEDDING SPECTACLE

> Hitherto, it must be emphasized, misrepresentations of China either on stage or on screen have been made without the cooperation of the Chinese themselves… Thus the effect of misrepresentation is not far reaching or deep-rooted. With the coming of more Chinese students to this country and their increasing interest in dramatic activities… it is not infrequent that a misjudgement of the occasion or a lack of fore-sight of the importance of their presentations on the part of the students has been found to do more harm to a correct interpretation of China than all of the other misrepresentations made by our foreign friends put together.
>
> —Tan Yuanlun 譚遠綸

In 1895, American dramatist Bertha M. Wilson published her *A Chinese Wedding*, a twenty-five-minute costume pantomime advertised as "a vivid and faithful picture of everything pertaining to the wedding ceremony in China."[81] The play was repeatedly performed in multiple Methodist Episcopal Churches across the nation to show a slice of Chinese life. By the time of the early 20th century, the staging of Chinese wedding ceremonies had become a recurring feature of Chinese plays on American stage. Few scenes offered a better opportunity than a wedding to display sumptuous costumes and elaborate decorations: A report on *The Son-Daughter*, a Chinese-themed play by George Scarborough and David Belasco staged at Ford's Opera House, remarked that the production's chief spectacle was the Chinese wedding "staged with gorgeous costuming." Similarly, a newspaper in Massachusetts announced that "A Chinese Wedding is to be a feature of the missionary entertainment…All are dressed in oriental costumes," while a report from Wisconsin advertised a "realistic portrayal of a Chinese Wedding" by the M. E. Church.[82] One description of such a performance reads as follows: "The church rostrum was decorated as the interior of a Chinese home. The family idols in all their pagan grandeur reposed in state on a table surrounded by red candles. The first scene depicted a

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[81] Hints Publishing Co., *Books & Plays* (New York: Hints Publishing Co., 1902), 32.
[82] "Chinese Wedding," *The Berkshire Eagle* (Pittsfield, MA), March 9, 1911, 9; "Portray Chinese Wedding; Leaguers Fill Actor Roles," *The Journal Times* (Racine, WI), April 26, 1913, 9.

Chinese merchant in flowing gown and greased pig tail sitting in his parlor."[83] These American stagings of Chinese weddings repeatedly asserted the authenticity of the ceremonies they purported to present. Yet could an "authentic" Chinese marriage be represented when the brides and grooms were performed by Ethel Benedict, Harry Gesbeck, Hubert Rogan, or Francia DuFour…? What was presented as "authentic" was not the complex social rituals, but a mere appearance: ornate props, richly decorated interiors, and elaborate costumes. Chinese wedding ceremonies, with their grandeur and beauty, exoticized by the Western gaze, were reduced to a material spectacle. American audiences, claiming that they know the real wedding from its "skin", were now confident to declare its superficiality.

Wedding ceremonies, with their popularity on American stage, were no surprise also a central theme in many CST performances. *Chinese Old-time Marriage*, staged by Chinese students at the University of Pennsylvania in 1916, was solely about a Chinese wedding ceremony. The entire play was consisted of two acts: "(1) the wedding ceremony, and (2) the [depiction of the] bride's room"[84] The recurrence of wedding ceremonies in CST can be understood through three factors: First, because many CST performances were organized to raise funds for famine relief, the exquisite spectacle of the wedding could attract American audiences and thereby enhance the success of these fundraising efforts. Second, as part of the cosmopolitan movement on American campuses, which aimed to promote cultural understanding among students of different nations, the Chinese wedding was an excellent example of Chinese culture. Lastly, since one of the central aims of CST was to replace the misrepresentation of Chinese in America, the weddings in CST were staged to correct the American misconceptions.

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[83] "Portray Chinese Wedding; Leaguers Fill Actor Roles," 9.
[84] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 12, no. 4 (February 1917): 224.

So did these wedding scenes Chinese students themselves produced successfully corrected American misconceptions? To avoid incorrections, Chinese students meticulously prepared their theatrical productions, making every effort to ensure the authenticity of what they represented onstage. See Shen Hong's detailed stage direction of the wedding scene in *The Wedded Husband*:

> A Chinese Marriage Ceremony: The walls are decorated with red silk; red carpets are on the floor. A table at center with four chairs. Candles are burning…The groom bows. The bride is given a mirror. The bride is also given one end of the red and green 'happy-silk'; the groom, the other end. The groom, helped by his best man, walk backward to the 'wedding apartment.' They walk on red cloth or red carpets which two servants are busy in arranging.[85]

Similarly, Cheng-Chin Hsiung [Xiong Zhengjin] wrote a very detailed scenic description in the beginning of his play, *The Thrice-Promised Bride*:

> The rise of the curtain, if a proscenium curtain is used, discloses a Chinese stage. There are two doors in the rear wall; the left for entrance, the right for exit. At each door there must be a curtain exquisitly embroidered with threads of gold and bright-colored silk; on the left door curtain the figure of a dragon, and on the right, the figure of a phoenix. In the center there is a table. The audience cannot see the table legs, for the table is curtained with a rich tapestry on which the figure of a unicorn is embroidered. On the table are pen-rack with Chinese pens; ink-stones, one for red ink, the other for black ink; a wooden block resembling a mallet; a massive wooden official seal; two carved bamboo holders for warrant-sticks; two wooden panels with the representation of a tiger's head and with Chinese inscriptions which signify to the Chinese that the scene is unmistakably in a district court.[86]

Yet despite their efforts to represent the authentic, there was simply no single, fixed reality of Chineseness; in fact, the content presented in these plays created new questions of representation. If the purpose of these entertainment programs was to educate Americans with real knowledge of China, then the Chinese students' attention to details had only made American audiences more confident of their Oriental knowledge. The students' Chinese identity alone

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[85] Hong Shen 洪深, "The Wedded Husband," *Poet Lore: A Magazine of Letters* 32, no. 1 (Spring 1921): 121.
[86] Cheng-Chin Hsiung, "The Thrice-Promised Bride," *The Carolina Magazine* (October 1923): 3–4.

seemed sufficient for American audiences to regard their performances as authentic representations of China. Therefore, the newspapers frequently noted facts like "the costumes are all products of the Orient, having been brought to this country by members of the Chinese Legation, students at Vassar, and members of the cast of the play," or that performers would wear "the native Chinese costume," many of which had come directly from "the wearers' native land."[87] As performance scholar James Moy reminds us, "those who rail against the dominant culture's imaging of Asians in America have tended to reinforce images of exoticism by focusing, for instance, on details of costume."[88] The reception of Chinese entertainment programs suggests that, in attempting to correct misrepresentation, Chinese students sometimes reproduced the exoticism they sought to challenge.

Many Chinese students were acutely aware of this exoticism. Reflecting on the 1925 production of *Pee Pa Chi*, Shiqiu Liang complained that what mattered most to American audiences were "the bright red and green costumes, a few vermilion pillars, the formal hats, shoes, beards, swinging sleeves, striding steps, and all those weird postures." But immediately, he also asked, "How many people actually understood *Pee Pa Chi*, including ourselves?"[89] Interestingly, Liang not only pointed out the superficiality of the American audiences, but also the limits of Chinese students' understanding of their own cultural traditions. If Westerners should not claim the authority to represent China, could Chinese students themselves fully do so? T. V. Soong expressed a similar doubt in his review of *See Yue Chee*: "Within the somewhat limited field of conveying to foreign audiences some conception of our traditions, customs and ideals, as well as in serving as illustrations, not representatives of Chinese art, our efforts can

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[87] *Ohio State Lantern* 38, no. 117 (April 11, 1919): 1; "Play to Blend East and West," *Detroit Free Press*, May 15, 1921, 69.
[88] James S. Moy, *Marginal Sights: Staging the Chinese in America* (Iowa City: University of Iowa Press, 1993), 5.
[89] Liang, *Liang Shiqiu zizhuan*, 117.

accomplish something. But wisdom for ourselves as well as justice to our culture demands that we refrain from claiming to perform the impossible feat of presenting real Chinese art."[90] In fact, Chinese students' presentation of Chinese culture, at least on the material level, was often far from accurate. Liang pointed out that the costumes in *Pee Pa Chi* were borrowed from *The Never-Ending Sorrow*, making the borrowing historically inappropriate because the characters in *Pee Pa Chi* belonged to the Han dynasty (202 BCE–220 CE), while the borrowed costumes were Tang in style (618–907 CE). Hong Shen, the student playwright of *The Wedded Husband*, also admitted that the "stage properties were not Chinese…the lanterns were Japanese, the furniture American."[91] Chinese students knew, at least to some extent, that correcting misconceptions required more than simply providing Americans with accurate information or presenting authentic objects.

The Rebelling Objects

On April 11th and 12th, 1919, Shen Hong, then a Chinese student of Ohio State University, staged *The Wedded Husband(TWH)* in the campus Chapel Hall in front of thirteen thousand audiences. The play is set in the home of an aristocratic family in Tientsin, China, "just after the revolution when nobles were still addressed by their titles and the people in general hesitated to break the old Chinese traditions."[92] *TWH* opens with two families, the Wangs and the Chens, preparing for the betrothal of Miss Wang and Master Chen. Miss Wang opposes the match because she is in love with Mr. Yang, an independent young man educated in the new schools. Nevertheless, she submits out of filial duty, while Mr. Yang, heartbroken, leaves for Mongolia before the wedding takes place. On the wedding day, however, Miss Wang suddenly faints after being infected by the highly contagious plague spreading in the city. Despite the

[90] Tse Vung Soong, "The Adventures of Don-Son," *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 10, no. 7 (1915): 457.
[91] *The Ohio State Lantern* (Columbus, OH), April 14, 1919, 1.
[92] Hong, "The Wedded Husband," 121.

doctor's warnings, the newlywed Master Chen insists on nursing her when everyone else gives her up. Under his care, Miss Wang recovers, but Master Chen dies of the plague himself. Tormented by guilt for having caused Sir Chen's death and nearly destroying his daughter's life, Lord Wang resolves not to inflict further misery and summons Mr. Yang back from Mongolia, arranging a second marriage that might at least bring his daughter happiness. Yet, upon learning that her husband sacrificed himself to save her, Miss Wang decides instead to uphold the sacred Chinese tradition that a woman, once married, may never marry again.

Hong wrote *TWH* with at least two audiences in mind: those who watch the performance and those who read it, and for both he takes extra care on the meanings of objects in the play.[93] In the published script, the opening stage direction pauses to explain the space of the performance that was almost irrelevant to the action of the play:

> "PLACE: Lord Wang's second reception room. (In the houses of aristocrats, there are generally three reception rooms: the big reception room, for polite guests, the second reception room, for intimate friends, and the Ladies' Reception Room, where the mistress of the house receives her friends.)"[94]

In the wedding scene, when the stage direction says the bride faints and drops the mirror, Hong even inserts a footnote explaining that the dropping of a mirror signifies misfortune. In the performance, Hong made the maid displays and names the betrothal gifts one by one, as if explaining to the audience:

> MAID. Yes, and on the table are your betrothal gifts. Here is a golden hair-pin, wishing you every satisfaction in your marriage. Here are a pair of silver buckles, which will bring good fortune to both of you. Here are embroidered silk bags, for the prosperity of your family, filled with peanuts that greet you with joyful long life. And tea. Happiness in your marriage. Eggs, painted red, you shall be much happier when you have a baby. Sugar, ah, yes, very sweet, very sweet. So beautiful, so graceful.[95]

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[93] *TWH* was initially written for Professor Louis A. Cooper's English Seminar.
[94] Hong, "The Wedded Husband," 129.
[95] Ibid., 115.

However, the scene shifts when Miss Wang, disappointed by her arranged marriage to Master Chen and answering the maid only with brief nods, suddenly points to a ring on the table:

> MISS WANG. What is that?
> MAID. A thumb ring.
> MISS WANG. A thumb ring for a betrothal gift! That means—from whom?
> MAID. Why so surprised? What does that mean?
> MISS WANG. That means good-bye for ever.[96]

The ring discerns from the other betrothal gifts for its personal connection; it refuses to speak unless Miss Wang pronounces its meaning. As the maid curiously asked for the meaning of the ring, the audience also anxiously waited for the signification. The same object therefore operates on two different levels: as a betrothal gift, whose meaning was fixed, and a private gift, intelligible only to those who share the emotional history. In this scene, Hong first reclaims the authority to define Chinese objects as a Chinese author, only for that meaning to flow once more into the hands of the character. Finally, the Chinese objects, fully absorbed, could no longer be reduced to simple materialistic spectacle.

The meaning of objects in *TWH* becomes even more complicated if we see the play as an intercultural encounter. As Man He argues in *Backstaging Modern Chinese Theatre*, the play makes Miss Wang assert her agency precisely by refusing the second marriage and following the Chinese tradition. In this way, the play reframes modern subjectivity within a traditional Confucian moral structure, and "promoted a global understanding of Chinese concepts of *qing*/love, loyalty, and filial piety by fashioning a transcultural discourse based on authentic sentiment."[97] In fact, Hong not only promoted traditional Chinese values through the affective power of the play, but also through a hybrid semiotic of the objects on stage.

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[96] Ibid.
[97] He, Backstaging Modern Chinese Theatre, 41.

After Lord Wang determined the second arranged marriage, he came into the room and ordered his daughter to change into a happy ceremonial dress:

> LORD WANG. I want you to meet Mr. Yang in your ceremonial dress. This color is too dull—looks like half mourning. Why don't you dress in red? That is the traditional color for happy occasions
>
> MADAM CHEN(formerly Miss Wang). But my father-in-law Would—
>
> LORD WANG. No, he will not object. The mourning period for your husband was over last week. Now I am going to order the servants to decorate the house. I don't want to see any white, I want everything in red. You do what I tell you.[98]

The order to remove all white and replace it with the "colors for happy occasions" is repeated several times throughout the rest of the play.[99] Shortly after Lord Wang exits, the maid urges Miss Wang to take off her mourning dress and put away all white things. When Mr. Yang arrives, a servant once again conveys Lord Wang's command that she receive him in a red dress. Miss Wang finally appears in a heavy white gown and announces that she will not marry again. Lord Wang asks "indignantly, sadly": "What do you mean by coming here in full mourning?"[100]

What does "white" signify here, or what could "white" signify beyond its immediate association with mourning in the context of the play? Could it also be the white ceremonial dress of the Western marriage tradition? Is it possible to interpret that when Lord Wang repeatedly ordered the removal of all "white" things, Hong was also demanding, through the character's mouth, the removal of "white" ways? The intercultural encounter between Chinese and Americans in the performance hall of *TWH* opened a third space for different readings and enunciation of cultural symbols. By wearing the white dress, Miss Wang asserts her agency as a modern Chinese woman by following the traditional Chinese values and refusing the Western

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[98] Hong, "The Wedded Husband," 129.
[99] In the traditional Chinese view, red is the color of marriage and happy occasions, while white is the color of mourning and burial ceremonies.
[100] Ibid., 134.

traditions. The “white dress” can be interpreted through multiple perspectives: it is at once the Chinese mourning dress, a sign of chastity, the color of a Western wedding dress, and an assertion of personal choice. It became a metaphor for the unstable Chineseness that resists hegemony of the dominant culture; an “in-between” Chineseness that is shaped neither just by the Confucian ethical memory nor just the pressure of Western modernity. Therefore, when Madam Chen finally emerges onstage in a "heavy mourning dress—White," and salutes, “all are startled.”[101]

“It must be remembered that this is a play, not a history or photograph,” concluded Hong in the opening speech of *TWH* one night.[102] What he meant by insisting that the play was neither history nor photograph should by now be clear: through performance, these objects escape the fate of being pinned as photos to a museum wall that are accompanied by brief historical explanation. The value of the performance did not lie in producing a perfectly accurate, ethnographic representation of Chinese marriage. Rather, it forces American audiences to notice the meaning behind the objects, empowered by a complicated history between them and the Chinese people who engaged with them. Under Hong’s presentation, the mirror, the betrothal gifts, the thumb rings, and the white dress are restored to the social, emotional, and ethical worlds from which they came. Instead of presenting ethnographic, self-exoticizing plays, *TWH* turned the Chinese objects that had once colluded with Orientalism against the Western anthropological gaze.

Gender or Racial Impersonation?

The *Ohio State Lantern* reported that the language of *TWH* is the only part of the play that is not Chinese. This claim is clearly inaccurate, for at least one aspect of the play was not

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[101] Ibid.
[102] *The Ohio State Lantern*, April 14, 1919, 1.

Chinese: the two female roles were played by two American students, Lorena L. Vogel and Madeline M. Tobias. Strangely, although both of their roles were significant in the play, neither the Chinese students nor the American audiences mentioned their parts at all. The lack of remarks on the mixed-racial casting notwithstanding, the appearance of both Chinese and American actors publicly on stage was unique to both Chinese students overseas and American audiences. The reason for this mixed-racial casting was likely practical. At Ohio State University at the time, there were no Chinese female students available to perform. Shen Hong, therefore, faced a limited choice: either borrow American women to play the female roles or have male Chinese students mimic the female characters; he decided on racial impersonation over gender impersonation.

The immediate problem raised by the casting choice is whether or not the part played by an American can be viewed as a form of yellowface performance. Although we cannot know precisely what Hong thought, the attitudes of other Chinese students at the time suggest that he likely considered racial impersonation, at least in itself, far less problematic than gender impersonation, provided that it was handled appropriately. Man He also rejected the idea that the performance was yellowface because the female character depicted was "neither caricatured nor humorous."[103] Further, she argues that Vogel did not wear a heavily ornamental costume except for the wedding dress she briefly appears in at the beginning of Act II, and neither she nor Tobias appears to have used makeup to simulate Asianness, which suggests that the play is unlikely to exoticize the female characters. Yet this dismissal seems too quick to justify excluding the play from the question of yellowface altogether. The costuming of Vogel and Tobias, despite its plainness, should still be considered as a technology that attempted to make them look Chinese. The absence of exaggerated makeup or overt caricature does not in itself eliminate the problem

[103] He, *Backstaging Modern Chinese Theatre*, 52.

of racial representation, and the lack of report on Vogel and Tobias might instead imply an emptiness of the perceived Chinese femininity, sufficiently constructed through clothes, makeup, and accessories. Therefore, it is necessary to dive deeper into the performance and discover what was really brought forth by the mixed-racial casting in *TWH*.

Yellowface performance, as Esther Kim Lee defines it, "describes the theatrical convention of using makeup, costumes, and visual technologies to transform someone to look East Asian." From the John Chinaman stereotype to *Madame Butterfly*, yellowface ranged from portraying Asian characters as barbaric, dangerous, and foolish to depicting them as luxurious, exotic, and fantastical. In the United States during the exclusion era, yellowface functioned as a technology of exclusion in at least two ways. First, it dramatized Asians as "suspicious and undesirable" and therefore "deserving of exclusion."[104] Second, it repeatedly marked Asians as foreign and other, keeping them outside the imagined boundaries of America(modernity). As yellowface developed, the white bodies replaced the Asian bodies, and were believed to be more suitable for performing the imaginary Asian, excluding the real Asian bodies both from the stage and their representations. In the case of female roles, white actresses performed Asian women in ways that showcased their theatrical skill by emphasizing the gap between staged Asianness and underlying white identity.[105] As *TWH* does not use caricature or racial jokes that demean Chinese images, it clearly did not operate in the first type. In addition, *TWH* clearly reverses the belief that white actresses were better performers of Asian characters, since newspaper coverage makes it clear that the casting decision was a reluctant choice. Most of the reports of the play did not

[104] Esther Kim Lee, *Made-Up Asians: Yellowface During the Exclusion Era* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2022), 20.
[105] Ibid., 170.

even mention the two girls, and when it mentioned, it made clear that they took the parts because "there are no Oriental girls in the University"[106] But did *TWH* reject the second type?

As Man He argues, Master Chen is carefully constructed as a figure who initially appears within familiar stereotypes of the Chinese man, only to emerge as a responsible husband who is "elegant and mature" and who "even problematizes the scientific reasons given by the Doctor for quarantine with his emotional appeal to love/qing."[107] Miss Wang, who later becomes Madam Chen, follows a similar trajectory that challenges conventional images of Chinese women. In the character notes, she is introduced as "a beautiful lady… Very quiet," and in the first two acts, she indeed remains largely silent except in her private room.[108] Yet Hong appears to foreshadow her transformation during the wedding: the guests are shocked when Miss Wang, as the bride, drops the mirror and speaks during the wedding, since a shattered mirror signifies misfortune and the bride should not speak before the guests. By the final act, Madam Chen is no longer silent, and now she declares her own decision in front of the assembled men of the play:

> MADAM CHEN. Father, father, you have always meant well. It is for my happiness that you arrange this second marriage for me.
>
> LORD WANG. Yes, my dear child, I regret my first doing.
>
> MADAM CHEN. When I promised you the first marriage, I prepared for a suffering life. But I am quite satisfied, quite happy now as it is. (Pauses) And father-in-law, you are so kind to me. (Pauses again) And Mr. Yang, how do you do? I am sorry for you. Our marriage is out of the question. Remember me as your friend—as your sister; but for that sacred love, the love between man and wife, (To LORD WANG) father, allow me to reserve it for my husband. He loved me and died. Good-bye, Mr. Yang.[109]

In this climactic speech, she addresses her father, her father-in-law, and Mr. Yang in turn, asserting her own ethical judgment. For both Chinese student audiences and American

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[106] *The Ohio State Lantern* 38, no. 116 (April 10, 1919): 1.
[107] He, *Backstaging Modern Chinese Theatre*, 51.
[108] Hong, "The Wedded Husband", 110.
[109] Ibid., 134-35.

spectators, she could no longer be reduced to the familiar fantasy of the silent, disciplined, or simply "beautiful" foreign woman.

The maid provides another example of how *TWH* departs from familiar representations of Chinese women. While Madam Chen requires time to grow into her final decision, the maid is decisive from the beginning. In the first act, she tries to dissuade her mistress from the first arranged marriage:

> MAID. Ah Koo Niang, think. *(In a low voice)* Now it is not yet too late.
> *(She pauses.)*
> MISS WANG. It is my father's wish.
> MAID. But his lordship would not force you to this marriage if you refused?
> MISS WANG. He is my father.
> MAID. But your happiness in the future?[110]

When Madam Chen faints during the wedding ceremony and her newlywed husband is helpless, the maid mocks him and declares that she wishes Mr. Yang were at her mistress's side instead. She is equally unafraid to defy Lord Wang's order and argues with her mistress. After hearing of the second arranged marriage, she also encourages her mistress to resist:

> MAID. You are not going to marry him?
> MADAM CHEN. Yes.
> MAID. (*Surprised*). You are?
> MADAM CHEN. It is my father's wish.
> MAID. Oh, his wish; he arranged for you again. Madam, madam, don't don't![111]

Importantly, the maid not only resists the conventional image of the docile Chinese woman, but also resonates in certain ways with the figure of the modern, independent American woman. Her cross-racial casting, therefore, suggests a layered identity in which Chineseness and Americanness are brought together through a shared gendered condition. As a white actress in Chinese costumes, speaking English while occasionally pronouncing Chinese words, the performer does not simply imitate a Chinese woman from the outside, but forms a camaraderie

[110] Ibid., 116.
[111] Ibid., 130.

with the character she played. In this process, the boundaries between the American actress and the Chinese role become blurred. Together, Madam Chen and the maid turn cross-racial casting away from the display of Chinese difference and toward a shared female struggle under the marriage system. For this reason, *TWH* did not produce a yellowface performance that dramatizes racial otherness; instead, it promoted empathy between the American actors with the Chinese characters. As part of the governing board of Ohio State's Cosmopolitan Club, Hong seems to project a cosmopolitan aspiration through the play: Above all nations lies the hope for a strong, independent woman.

A New Chinese Wedding

The next section turns to two plays: Miss Dorothy Wong's *The Greatest Event in Life* and Yuxiu Gu's *Guo Shou* 國手. Together, they reveal new models of Chinese marriage that differ sharply from the spectacular traditional Chinese wedding familiar on the Western stage. The first questions whether marriage should remain the defining event in a young woman's life at all, while the second presents a simplified modern wedding closely tied to patriotism. The two plays presented the complex transformation of Chinese weddings under the pressure of modernity, and together invited both Chinese students and American audiences to imagine a new Chineseness, one characterized by change.

To understand the new marriages in these plays, however, it is first necessary to situate them within the broader discourse of *wenming jiehun* (civilized marriage) that emerged in late Qing and early Republican China. From the late nineteenth century into the early twentieth century, as Western wedding rituals gradually entered China, some intellectuals and overseas students began experimenting with ways of combining Chinese and Western ceremonial forms. By adopting elements of Western weddings such as simplicity and publicity while discarding

their religious components, reformers helped shape a new ideology of marriage commonly known as *wenming jiehun*. Yet *wenming jiehun* should not be understood as merely an imitation to the West; the term was received and interpreted in different ways by Chinese writers and reformers. Xiangru Qian 錢相如, for instance, links the cost of personal weddings to the condition of the national economy and argues for the superiority of *wenming jiehun* over traditional practice in three practical respects: it saves money, saves trouble, and saves labor.[112] Alternatively, Ke Xu's 徐珂 account in *Qingbai leichao* (Classified Collection of Qing Anecdotes) 清稗類鈔 presents civilized marriage as a reform of the old marriage system, but emphasizes somewhat different features. He wrote:

> First, marriage should proceed by combining parental approval and the matchmaker's arrangement with the consent of the man and woman, thereby placing freedom under supervision. The sequence is as follows: first, the man states his wish to his parents; once they approve, an intermediary is asked to present the proposal to the woman's parents; once her parents also approve, the intermediary arranges a meeting between the man and woman. Only when both parties agree is the marriage contract established.
>
> Second, After the engagement, the man and woman make a pact, first pledging themselves to pursue education and achieve self-reliance.
>
> Third, The wedding ceremony should be conducted with frugality, in order to correct the custom of extravagance and remove obstacles to economic life. On the wedding day, the parents of both the bride and groom should each provide a gold ring and one set of formal attire.[113]

Another writer, Yaquan Du 杜亞泉, acknowledged the influence of the West, but he was critical of the term civilized marriage itself. As he observed, to call it civilized seemed to imply that Chinese wedding rituals were inherently uncivilized. Yet, he argued, "Chinese marriage

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[112] "省錢...省事...省力" Xiangru Qian 錢香如, "Wenming jiehun yanshuo jiaoben" 文明結婚演說腳本 [Script for a Speech on Civilized Marriage], Fanhua zazhi 繁華雜誌, no. 5 (1915): 19–20.

[113] "一, 以父母之命, 媒妁之言, 而取男女之同意, 以監督自由。其辦理次序, 先由男子陳志願於父母, 得父母允准, 即延介紹人請願於女子之父母, 得其父母允准, 再由介紹人約期訂邀男女會晤, 男女同意, 婚約始定。二, 定婚後, 男女立約, 先以求學自立為誓言。三, 婚禮務求節儉, 以挽回奢侈習俗, 而免經濟生活之障礙。結婚之日, 當由男女父母各給以金戒指一事, 禮服一襲。" Ke Xu 徐珂, "Wenming jiehun" 文明結婚 [Civilized Marriage], in Qingbai leichao 清稗類鈔 [Classified Collection of Qing Anecdotes], vol. 5 (Beijing: Zhonghua Shuju, 1984), 1987.

contained both ancient rites and contemporary practices; what was truly uncivilized was not Chinese ritual as such, but only its vulgar customs." Therefore, he proposed to discard the customs of the luxurious costumes and the cumbersome rituals that oppressed the bride and burdened the ceremony with empty formalities marked by superstition and impropriety.[114]

The idea that traditional Chinese marriage oppressed the bride is clearly reflected in *The Greatest Event in Life*. Being the first play published by a female Chinese student in America, it was produced in 1926 at Earl Hall, Columbia university by Columbia Chinese students' club with an all women cast. The play opens with a conversation between two Chinese female students, Li-ying and Pauling, who hold sharply different views of marriage. Pauling argues that marriage is no longer a necessity, since highly educated women like herself should pursue independent careers, while Li-ying insists that she could still contribute to the community starting at home. The plot then reveals the engagement between Li-ying and Wei. Although Li-ying's father initially opposes the match because he is not involved in the decision, he eventually consents, acknowledging that "time has so changed that neither we nor fate can decide the destiny of our children."[115] It ends with Li-ying and Wei discussing the money required for their wedding, when Li-ying suddenly begins to question whether marriage should be the greatest event in life at all. The play not only presents a debate between a traditional Chinese marriage and the civilized wedding, but also two different views of the civilized wedding. While Pauling chooses a more Westernized lifestyle and decides to contribute to the world by working as a researcher at the Rockefeller Foundation, Li-ying, who likewise recognizes her abilities and responsibilities as a highly educated woman, believes that her charity

[114] "雖然，吾國婚禮，有古禮，有今禮。而所謂不文明者，特俗禮耳。" Yaquan Du 杜亞泉 (pseud. Cangfu 傖父), "Wenming jiehun" 文明結婚 [Civilized Marriage], Dongfang zazhi 東方雜誌 14, no. 5 (May 1917): 12–15.
[115] *The Chinese Students' Monthly* 22, no. 8 (June 1927): 19.

should begin at home. Li-ying's perspective reflects a familiar Chinese value, *xiu qi zhi ping* 修齊治平, that is, one should first cultivate the self and regulate the family before governing the state and bring peace to the world. This tension is reinforced by the play's scenography. Set in a moment when "the West marches into the East," the stage directions describe a room that is "Occidental" except for "the moon door in the rear which discloses a partial view of a Chinese garden," and that is furnished with "Western furniture and Chinese hangings and antiques."[116] Rather than producing a harmonious fusion, this setting places Chinese and Western cultural signs in visible contiguity. The domestic space thus mirrors the ideological condition of the characters, who live between competing understandings of marriage, gender, and modernity.

Wong does not allow either position to fully triumph. Pauling chooses a more independent life, but still acknowledges the value of the home; Li-ying accepts marriage, yet refuses to accept it uncritically as the only "greatest event in life." The closing of the play beautifully elaborates the ambivalence:

> LI-YING. I was thinking that father's wish has completely ignored the great event of my life.
> WEI. And what's that?
> LI-YING. My service to the community.
> WEI. Don't you always say, charity begins at home? You see, my dear, we are entering into a partnership. The success or failure in life will depend upon the partners. That's why I agree with your father that marriage is the greatest event in life.
> LI-YING. One of the greatest, perhaps. Pauling has a job; that will be her life career.
> WEI. There are career and career. Marriage is one. To me you have followed the most important one.
> (As the curtain closes, they look at each other, embrace, and about to kiss, but she buries her head in his coat.)

An audience of the play may wonder what Li-ying is thinking when the play closes with her last gesture. Although hiding her hesitation by burying her head from Wei, the struggle of her between different values was revealed to the audiences. She does not turn away from marriage,

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[116] Ibid., 16.

yet neither does she surrender herself unreservedly to a romantic union. The final action of Li-ying embodied the unresolved tension between the two different views of *wenming jiehun.* For Chinese student audiences and American spectators alike, the ending offered not a fixed essence of Chinese womanhood, but a Chineseness in transformation, one constantly being remade under the intercultural encounter between Chinese and the West.[117]

While *The Greatest Event in Life* offers a dynamic Chineseness by presenting a dispute over different perspectives toward *wenming jiehun*, Yu Su Koo's *Guo Shou* produced a different model of it. The play was produced as part of the Double Ten Celebration by the Chinese students of M.I.T. on October 9, 1924 in the E.M.E. Church in Cambridge, Massachusetts. The plot centers on Dr. P. T. Wang, a Chinese student at Harvard, returns home after learning that his mother's illness has worsened because his elder brother insists on joining the Chinese civil war. His arrival helps restore his mother's health. He then learns that his sister who he has long loved was adopted by his parents. They immediately decide to marry and to hold their wedding ceremony on the thirteenth anniversary of the founding of the Republic of China. In the final part of the play, Dr. Wang's elder brother, having witnessed the cruelty of war, also returns home and declares that Chinese people must stop fighting among themselves. The play ends with the family joyfully reunited, singing the national anthem together.

In Act III, after deciding the marriage, Dr. Wang proposed to his sister to keep the marriage simple and hold the ceremony on the national day:

> DR.WANG. Sister, I already discussed with our mother. Let us keep the wedding simple and finish it early. Today is National Day, and a few of my classmates will come to celebrate our National Day commemoration. I want to take this important day as the special occasion to complete the greatest event in our lives. What do you think?
> Z. H. WANG. Today is truly an important day. If, because of our marriage, you would from now on strengthen your determination to serve our nation, then, when the time come

[117] Ibid., 20.

> of our golden wedding anniversary fifty years from now, our nation would surely grow out of the storm-tossed and precarious time as they are today.
> DR. WANG. Well said! Then let us pray sincerely that today will be the first day of our new life serving relentlessly for our country![118]

Under Koo's arrangement, marriage is no longer a personal affair between the two loved ones , but a promise that is tied to the fate of the nation. The usual good prayers like *Zao Sheng Gui Zi*(May you soon have a child) 早生貴子 and *Bai Tou Xie Lao*(May you live long together) 白頭偕老 were replaced by their wishes to unite as the better servers of the nation. Furthermore, the luxurious ornamentals and the complex rituals that characterize Chinese weddings completely disappear. Instead, it was replaced by a continual parallel between marriage and patriotism: It was suggested that Dr. Wang should wear two rings on his hand, one to remember the bride and another, bearing the national flag on it, to commemorate the country.

The marriage between Dr. Wang and Z. H. Wang thus reworks Ke Xu's model of *wenming jiehun*. It follows the general structure he outlines: the match is arranged through an intermediary, Dr. Wang's uncle; it receives parental approval; and it preserves the consent of the couple, who had long loved one another before the proposal was formalized. Yet Koo also transforms this reformist model in a distinctly nationalist direction. Xu Ke's post-engagement vow to pursue education and self-reliance becomes, in *Guo Shou*, a pledge that "today will be the first day" of their "new life serving relentlessly for our country." Likewise, the gold ring associated with *wenming jiehun* is supplemented by an iron ring bearing the national flag, so that the ceremony commemorates not only the lovers but also the nation. In this way, *Guo Shou* recast marriage as a patriotic rite in which conjugal union and national service become inseparable.

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[118] Yuxiu Gu, *Gu Yuxiu quanji* [*Complete Works of Gu Yuxiu*], vol. 2 (Shenyang: Liaoning Education Press, 2000), 452.

Summary

In this chapter, I have explored how Chinese students challenged the Orientalist representations of Chinese weddings on the American stage and reimagined new conceptions of Chineseness through their theatrical performances. While Chinese students initially attempted to correct Western misconceptions by presenting authentic Chinese cultural objects and traditions, they soon developed different strategies. In *The Wedded Husband*, Shen Hong transformed wedding objects from mere material spectacles into meaningful symbols whose significance was constantly reinterpreted through performance. The play's cross-racial casting further challenged conventional representations of Chinese women, and presented a shared female struggle that transcended racial and national boundaries. Meanwhile, *The Greatest Event in Life* and *Guo Shou* presented two different models of *wenming jiehun*, the new Chinese marriage. Together, these performances negotiate the meanings of Chinese traditions, gender, and modernity, producing a changing, "in-between" Chineseness.

EPILOGUE

According to the most up-to-date information from the Institute of International Education, 265,919 Chinese international students were enrolled in American higher education or participating in Optional Practical Training during the 2024-2025 academic year.[119] By comparison, only 239 Chinese students were studying in the United States in 1909, when the Boxer Indemnity Scholarship Program began.[120] Yet despite this extraordinary increase in population, Chinese students continue to encounter racial prejudice and suspicion in American society. In 2020, the U.S. Department of State published a report titled *The Chinese Communist Party on Campus: Opportunities & Risks*, warning that Chinese Students and Scholars Associations (CSSAs) and Confucius Institutes could serve as instruments of Chinese Communist Party (CCP) influence and propaganda. The report further raised concerns that the CCP could recruit or pressure students into transferring sensitive research and technology to China.[121] A survey of 1252 Chinese graduate students conducted four years later found that 60 percent of respondents had experienced discrimination on campus, and 11 percent reported being accused of spying for China by other students or professors.[122] Should we not be alarmed by the striking parallels between today's political climate and the hostility and xenophobia that characterized the Chinese Exclusion era?

On the other hand, for Chinese students in the twenty-first century, it has become increasingly difficult to define their own identities or even determine what it means to represent

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[119] Institute of International Education, "China: Country and Area Facts and Figures 2025," Open Doors 2025 Report on International Educational Exchange (2025), opendoorsdata.org.
[120] Huping Ling, "A History of Chinese Female Students in the United States, 1880s–1990s," Journal of American Ethnic History 16, no. 3 (Spring 1997): 82.
[121] U.S. Department of State, *The Chinese Communist Party on Campus: Opportunities & Risks* (Washington, DC: U.S. Department of State, 2020), 2, state.gov(accessed June 6, 2026).
[122] Igor Himelfarb, Neli Esipova, Frank Laczko, and Alexander Anokhin, *Study of Chinese Graduate Students in the United States: A Multidimensional Survey* (Multicultural Insights, 2024), 20, multiculturalinsights.net.

Chinese. The rejection of traditional Chinese culture, which began with the late Qing reform movements, intensified during the May Fourth Movement, and reached its peak during the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), disrupted the continuity between contemporary Chinese students and their cultural heritage. Meanwhile, the revival of traditional Chinese learning in the twenty-first century has further complicated their relationship with these traditions. In the political realm, questions of territorial boundaries and sovereignty have further complicated the meaning of Chineseness. The Chinese world encompasses distinct political and cultural communities across the "Two Shores and Three Lands," each shaped by its own historical experiences and contested understandings of Chinese identity.[123]

Fortunately, Chinese students can still turn to the power of theatre to navigate these challenges. In 2025, 33 of the universities ranked among the top 50 by *U.S. News & World Report* had Chinese-language theatre clubs that regularly organized performances by Chinese international students.[124] Unlike their predecessors in the early twentieth century, who often sought to introduce Chinese culture to American audiences, many contemporary Chinese international student theatre primarily produce Chinese-language plays for Chinese-speaking audiences. These productions provide students with a culturally familiar space within American institutions, where they can temporarily escape the language barriers and sense of foreignness they encounter in everyday life. By performing plays set in their homeland, they can recreate a familiar cultural environment and momentarily relive their experiences in China.

Nevertheless, some contemporary CSTs have also begun experimenting with bilingual productions. The emergence of bilingual theatre within CIST communities reveals the hybrid linguistic and cultural realities of Chinese international students. They often embody the

[123] Two Shores and Three Places refer to the People Republic of China(Mainland China), Republic of China(Taiwan), and Special Administration Regions(Hong Kong and Macau)
[124] The data is collected by the author in 2025.

diglossic and code-switching that characterize the daily speech of Chinese international students. In January 2025, Chinese artist Zhen Yu Meng staged a bilingual play titled *Nian Ye Fan*. The play depicts a northern Chinese family's New Year's Eve gathering, where unspoken tensions and buried emotions quietly surface. Originally intended to be performed entirely in Chinese, the production became bilingual after the inclusion of a cast member "more fluent in English than Chinese." As Meng explains, "Theatre is the actor's presentation… It's about seeing how each of them fits and expresses the material in their own way. Speaking in both languages also reflects her experience of thinking in two different languages, each representing a distinct mode of thought."[125] For her, the actress's transition between Chinese and English functions as an act of reexamining the mother–daughter relationship through two distinct modes of consciousness. Wisteria, the founder of Vermillion Theatre 朱雀劇團, also claims that she and the team "identify as bilingual speakers, and [being bilingual] is the environment we feel most comfortable in creating. Sometimes we struggle with sticking to strictly English or strictly Chinese when it comes to deep-level communication."[126] The emergence of bilingual theatre among Chinese students demonstrates their growing embrace of an alternative Chineseness shaped by their diasporic experiences.

I would therefore conclude this thesis on a hopeful note: Chinese students have been performing on American stages for more than a century. Although historical circumstances have changed profoundly, Chinese students continue to use theatre as a means of making themselves visible to others and understanding themselves. The contradictions between Chinese traditions and Western modernity have not been, and may never be, fully resolved through performance. Nor can theatre alone eliminate racial discrimination or political hostility. Yet it continues to

[125] Zhenyu Meng, interview by the author, conducted in Chinese and translated by the author, October 9, 2025.
[126] Wisteria, interview by the author, October 3, 2025.

provide Chinese students with a space to confront these complexities, negotiate their identities, and imagine new possibilities of being Chinese. Thus, the play must go on.

Appendix A

Table of CST Productions in the United States, 1906-1931[127]

Year	Title	Location/Who	Language
1907	*Our Old Happy School Day*	College Street Hall, Yale	Chinese; English
1907	*A Chinese School*	Harvard Union	Chinese; English
1910	*When the East and the West Meet*	Houston Hall, University of Pennsylvania	N/A
1911	A "Mock Parliament in China"*	New York Chinese Students' Club	N/A
1911	*All for a Rose**	The Cathay Club at University of California	
1911	*N/A*	Central Branch of the Young Women's Christian Association of New York City	English
1912	*Every Student**	Flip-Flap Club at East Section Annual Conference	N/A
1912	*The Chinese Revolution in a Nutshell**	MIT Chinese Students' Club, at Eastern Section Annual Conference	N/A
1912	*New Play*	University of California	N/A
1913	*Chinese School Life*	Yale	Chinese

[127] Items marked with an asterisk (*) were compiled by Tong Hui in *Performing Chinese Authenticity: Chinese Student Drama in the United States, 1910–1923*. The original sources for these entries have not been independently verified by the author.

1913	*The Gift of Self**	Female students at the Barnard Church Club	N/A
1913	*Glimpses of Chinese Medicine*	Houston hall, University of Pennsylvania	N/A
1914	*N/A*	Y.M.C.A. building, San Francisco	N/A
1914; 1915	*A Pilgrim's Progress (The Adventure of Don son (the Priest)/ See Yue Chee)*	Copley hall, Boston	Chinese
1914	*President of the Chinese Republic**	YMCA Annual Conference at Northfield	N/A
1914	Mock Wedding Show*	YWCA Annual Conference at Silver Bay	N/A
1914	*Formosa under the Iron Hand*	Imperial Theatre	Chinese
1914	*The Hang Number Letter*	Barnes Hall, Cornell	English
1914	*When the Old Meets the New*	Houston Hall, University of Pennsylvania	N/A
1916	*Old Cronies*	Chinese Evangelical Mission, Chicago	N/A
1916	*Spanking the City God*	Yale	N/A
1916	*Spanking of the District Gods*	Earl hall, Columbia	N/A
1916	*The Hen-Pecked Husband*	Gymnasium of the College for Women of the Western Reserve University	Chinese
1916	*New Order Cometh*	Philips Academy, Andover, Massachusetts	N/A

1915	*The Intruder*	Brinkerhof Theatre, New York	English
1916	*All Nation Revue**	University of Michigan Cosmopolitan Club	N/A
1916	*The Chinese Old-time Marriage*	Houston Hall, University of Pennsylvania	N/A
1917	*Illinois Alumni Reunion*	Morrow Hall, University of Illinois	N/A
1917	*The Woman Hater*	Lathrop Hall, University of Wisconsin Madison	N/A
1918	*Moonland*	Lathrop Hall, University of Wisconsin Madison	N/A
1918	*The New Soul of the Nation*	Cambridge, Massachusetts	N/A
1919	*The Wedded Husband*	University Chapel, Ohio State University	English
1918; 1919	*Kultur vs. Democracy*	Grinnell University	English
1919	*The Hang Number Letter*	Philips Brooks House, Harvard	English
1919	*Faithfulness, Devotion, and Sacrifice (Shao Jeh Yee)*	Schenley Theatre, Pittsburg	English
1919	*The Man Hater*	Ohio State University	N/A
1919	*Democracy in China**	Celebration of the Chinese republic at YMCA at University of Michigan	N/A
1919	*Rainbow*	Agricultural Hall, Iowa State University	English
1920	*The Hang Number Letter*	Barnes Hall, Cornell	English

1920	*Rainbow*	Morrow Hall, University of Illinois	English
1920	*For Romeo and Juliet*	Harvard Union	English
1920	*The Lamb Husband*	Harvard Union	Chinese
1920	*The Registered Letter*	Likely New York	English
1920	*The Seven Nights of the Seventh Moon*	Earl Hall, Columbia University	N/A
1920	*Monuments Five*	Earl Hall, Columbia University	N/A
1920	*Between Smiles and Tears*	Lathrop Hall, University of Wisconsin Madison	Chinese
1920	*The Old School Day*	Methodist Episcopal Church,Wilkinsburg, Pennsylvania	English
1920	*The Rising Giant*	Carnegie Music Hall, University of Pennsylvania	English
1920	*The Purdue Product*	Eliza Fowler Hall, Purdue	N/A
1920	*China Past and Present*	Morrow Hall, University of Illinois	English
1920	*A Personal Choice**	Chinese students at Stanford	N/A
1921	*N/A*	Commercial Hall, Boston	Chinese
1921	*The Dream of the Red Chamber*	Symphony Hall	Pantomime
1921	*Rainbow*	Nast Gamble auditorium, Baldwin-wallace	English
1921	*Rejuvenation*	Oriental Consistory, Chicaco	N/A
1921	*Wandering Dragon*	Central M.E. Church Auditorium, Detroit	English

1921	*Mulan*	New York, Columbia, Earl Hall(Dress Rehearsal); New York, Cort Theatre; New York, Century Roof; New York, Philipsburgh Hall; New Haven, Yale, Hyperion Theatre; New Jersey, Montclaire, High School Auditorium; Washington D.C., Central High School, Belasco Theatre.	English
1921	*Cheney Family*	N/A	N/A
1921	*The Yellow Jacket*	N/A	N/A
1921	*The Willow Pattern Plate*	International Students' House May Festival at Philadelphia	N/A
1922	*Execution scene of The Yellow Jacket*	Bellevue-Stratford ball room, Philadelphia	English
1922	*Sacrifice*	Lowell Textile School	English
1922	*The Fisherman's Luck*	Walker Memorial Hall, Cambridge, Massachusetts	Pantomime
1922	*On the Eve of Double Ten*	Eliza Fowler Hall, Purdue	N/A
1923	*The Flower Ball*	Philomusian Club, University of Pennsylvania	N/A

1923	*The Jade Bracelet*	Campus Theatre, Cornell	N/A
1923	*N/A*	Auditorium of Byers Hall, Yale	English
1923	*An Unknown Private*	Lathrop Hall, University of Wisconsin-Madison	English
1923	*Empty City Stratagem*	Lathrop Hall, University of Wisconsin-Madison	Chinese
1923	*N/A*	Read Hall, University of Missouri	N/A
1923	*Cowherd and the Weaving Maid*	University Chapel, University of Ohio State	English
1924	*The Gold Bracelet*	N/A	N/A
1924	*Singing Highway Man*	Haverford	English
1924	*Guo Shou* 国手	E.M.E. Church, Cambridge, Massachusetts	N/A
1924	*Cowherd and the Weaving Maid*	N/A	English
1924	*The Never-ending Sorrow*	New York International House	English
1925	*Pee Pa Chi*	Boston Fine Art Theatre	English
1925	*Nation's Wound*	Syracuse University	Chinese
1925	*Sorrow in a Chinese Palace*	Bates Hall, Boston	Pantomime
1925	*The Chinese Ghost land*	New York, International House	N/A
1925	*The Cowherd and the Weaving Maid*	Northern High School	English

1925	*The Virtue's Victim*	Illinois	English
1925	*Queen of Hearts*	Earl Hall, Columbia University	N/A
1925	*Boston Music Circle play*	Denison house, Boston	N/A
1926	*Climbing Three Steps at one Stride &*	Earl Hall, Columbia University	Chinese
1926	*The Greatest Event in Life*	Earl Hall, Columbia University	English
1926	*The Thrice Promised Bride*	N/A	English
1926	*Puppets of Fate*	Lan Hall, University of Michigan Ann Arbor	N/A
1926	*International Night Play*	Iowa	N/A
1927	*The Thrice Promised Bride*	Henderson Hall, Illinois	N/A
1928	*The Spirit of Chinese Youth*	Little Theatre	English
1929	*Molan (Muh Lan)*	New York International House	N/A
1929	*Milky Way (Seventh Eve of the Seventh Moon)*	New York International House	N/A
1929	*Tien Kwan Tsi Fu*	Social Hall, Massachusetts Institution of Technology	N/A
1929	*Lau Yu Woon*	Social Hall, Massachusetts Institution of Technology	N/A

1929	*The Henpecked Husband*	Social Hall, Massachusetts Institution of Technology	N/A

Appendix B

Table for CST with Surviving Scripts

Title	Author	Place to find them
The Spirit of Chinese Youth	Tim Min Tieh	*Chinese Students' Monthly*, vol. 23, no. 8 (1928), 25–28
The Thrice Promised Bride	Chen-Chin Hsiung [Zhengjin Xiong] 熊正瑾	*The Carolina Magazine*, October, 1923, 3-9.
The Marvelous Romance of Wen Chun-Chin	Chen-Chin Hsiung [Zhengjin Xiong] 熊正瑾	*Poet Lore*, vol. 35, no. 2 (Summer 1924), 298-313.
The Hang-Number Letter	Yuan Ren Chao [Yuanren Zhao] 赵元任	Carton 32 Folder 2, Series 7. Personalia Subseries 7.2. Early writings and class notes, Chao (Yuen Ren) papers, BANC MSS 83/30 c, Bancroft Library, University of California at Berkeley.
The Wedded Husband	Shen Hong 洪深	*Poet Lore*, vol. 32, no. 1 (Spring 1921), 110–125.
The Cowherd and the Weaving Maid	Shen Hong 洪深	Part I: *Chinese Students' Monthly*, vol. 15, no. 6(1920),

		50-53. Part II: *Chinese Students' Monthly*, vol. 15, no. 7(1920), 46-53.
For Romeo and Juliet	Shen Hong 洪深	*Chinese Students' Monthly*, vol. 15, no. 6 (1928), 25–28.
The Intruder	Peng Chun Zhang [Pengchun Zhang] 張彭春	Cui, Guoliang 崔國良, ed. 2009. Nankai Huaju Shiliao Congbian 南開話劇史料叢編 [Collection of Historical Materials on Nankai Spoken Drama]. Tianjin: Nankai Daxue Chubanshe.
The Greatest Event in Life	Miss Dorothy Wong	*Chinese Students' Monthly*, vol. 22, no. 8 (1927), 16–20.
国手	Yusu Koo [Yuxiu Gu] 顧毓琇	Gu, Yuxiu 顧毓琇. 2000. Gu Yuxiu Quanji 顧毓琇全集 [The Complete Works of Gu Yuxiu]. Vol. 2, Drama. Shenyang: Liaoning Jiaoyu Chubanshe.

国殇	Yusu Koo [Yuxiu Gu] 顧毓琇	Gu, Yuxiu 顾毓琇. *Gu Yuxiu Quanji* 顾毓琇全集 [The Complete Works of Gu Yuxiu], vol. 2, Drama. Shenyang: Liaoning Education Press, 2000, 457-488.
Kultur vs. Democracy	H. C. Chen	*The Chinese Students' Christian Journal* 5, no. 1 (November 1918), 56-60.

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